

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SATURDAY 3 OCTOBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



BETWEEN APRIL AND OCTOBER, ACROSS TWO YEARS, NOT ONE DAY AT MARINA BARRAGE AVERAGED TWELVE KILOMETRES AN HOUR (P17)

THE RABBIT HOLE

The brand that invented quad kites no longer makes the best ones. Its patents ran out and two workshops took the category

THE ATELIER

The grail rice cooker buys you five degrees Celsius. Fifty batches put a cheaper machine on top

THE DIARY

November's sumo sold out on a date most people never knew was the date

THIS ISSUE · NO. 121

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FROM THE DESK

“A certain amount of opposition is a great help to a man. Kites rise against not with the wind. Even a head wind is better than nothing.”

John Neal, “Enterprise and Perseverance,” *Weekly Mirror* (New York), 1846 — universally attributed to Churchill, who was born twenty-eight years after it was printed¹

A reserve release that lifted the price. A payroll miss that sold off bonds.

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY’S CLOSE

US 2-year	4.83%	▲ 2bp
US 10-year	5.28%	▲ 11bp
US 30-year	5.63%	▲ 14bp
VWRA	\$192.74	▼ 0.40%
DXY	101.92	▲ 0.94%
USD/SGD	1.2772	▼ 0.16%
Brent	\$102.70	▲ 0.40%
Gold	\$4,142.22	▼ 0.85%
Bitcoin	\$84,503	▼ 0.12%

Day moves at Friday’s close; weekly and monthly shape on **p14**. Not advice.²

THE SCOREBOARD · SATURDAY — EIGHTY-ONE CLAIMS CAME DUE. FIFTY-FIVE RIGHT, TWENTY-THREE WRONG, TWO UNRESOLVABLE

WRONG, and the worst of them. We said the fourth-quarter electricity tariff would rise “toward the modelled 20–25 per cent range.” It **fell 10.4 per cent**. Direction wrong, magnitude wrong, our own model.

WRONG ×3, RIGHT ×1 — on the same meeting. Nos. 84, 87 and 93 said the Fed would not hike in September. No. 94 said it would. It did, **12–0**. The minority view was the correct one.

SOURCES ¹Quote Investigator’s researched entry: John Neal’s “Enterprise and Perseverance,” *Weekly Mirror*, 1846, with an 1828 antecedent; Churchill attributions first appear in 1963, after his birth. ²Levels at the close of 2 October 2026, sourced on **p14**. ³Every Scoreboard row was graded against a primary record — the Committee’s statement, the utility’s tariff page, the trade agency’s monthly report, the festival’s award record, box-office trackers and price histories. Eighty-one claims fell due, eighty were graded, and one is left ungraded rather than guessed.

RIGHT on the number, WRONG on the point. The “narrow export boom” call needed exports above 15 per cent and non-electronics negative. Exports printed **+46.2%**; non-electronics flipped to **+12.0%**.

The pattern worth admitting. Every row predicting no Western major would pick up an Undercurrent subject won. **Both** predicting a feature *would* follow lost.³

THE WORLD • THE RESERVES OPEN

Seven governments opened their tanks on Friday. The barrel they cannot reach went up

One hundred million barrels over four months, diesel first and frontloaded. Brent rose; West Texas fell nearly two per cent. The eleven-dollar gap between them is the reply.

The commitment is one sentence long. The G7 will implement “a co-ordinated release through the IEA of 100 million barrels (MB) to begin immediately over four months,” including “a frontloaded substantial diesel release within the first 20 days,” with a pledge to refrain from export restrictions between members. France holds the presidency. Canada, which keeps no strategic reserve, will stagger refinery maintenance instead.¹

What moved it was a threat. Washington had floated a ban on US diesel exports, which Europe had rejected; an overnight Macron-Trump call closed the gap. Analysts put such a ban at **forty to fifty per cent** on European wholesale prices — the number the statement was written to avoid.²

\$11.48

BRENT MINUS WEST TEXAS AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE — **\$102.70**
AGAINST \$91.22, BRENT UP 0.40 PER CENT AND WTI DOWN
 1.78 PER CENT IN THE SAME SESSION, ON THE DAY THE
 RESERVES OPENED³

The scale is the first problem. Spread evenly, a hundred million barrels is about **830,000 a day** against roughly 103 million of daily global demand — under one per cent. Against the Gulf it is worse: Kpler put **16.5 million barrels a day** leaving the Middle East in September, close to prewar. The whole release is **about six days** of that outflow.³

The second is that crude is not the shortage. Diesel is. American on-highway diesel averaged **\$6.382 a gallon** in the week to 28 September, down 14.7 cents, after a record \$6.52 on the twenty-second; European diesel has reached **€2.24 a litre** against €1.59 before the war began in February. And US distillate stocks stood at **105,180 thousand barrels** on 25 September — below the 107,859 of two weeks earlier that was reported everywhere as the record low.⁴

DOHA

AL JAZEERA

Files it as Trump's trophy rather than the G7's decision — the headline is the man, not the communiqué — quoting him that Europe had “just agreed to release a massive amount of their heavily stocked Diesel Oil.”⁵

LYON

EURONEWS

Reads the same document as European capitulation under American pressure, and alone leads with the engineering: “Crude releases don't automatically translate to diesel supply increases. Refineries must process the oil.”⁶

THE CHATTER • WHAT BEIJING MADE OF IT, AND WHAT IT MADE OF NOTHING

Xinhua's English index carried it as “G7 to release 100 mln barrels of diesel in 4 months.” The statement says a hundred million barrels of oil and products, of which diesel is the frontloaded part; the headline converts the whole figure into the scarce one. *This desk read the index, not the article — a headline, not a story.* **Global Times ran nothing at all:** no release, no Hormuz, no carrier. Its Friday leads were Golden Week tourism, a fighter sale, and pandas. Hacker News had nothing; Reddit refused this desk on every route.⁷

THE SCEPTIC • THE TAPE DISSENTED INSIDE THE HOUR

No analyst was required. **Brent rose on the day the reserves opened.** The release lands in the Atlantic basin; the premium lives east of Hormuz. One analysis relays Goldman Sachs putting the effect at **around half the recent price rise** — a ceiling, not a floor — easing distillates “over the next four to eight weeks, not resolve it,” since neither Russian export restrictions nor the strait is addressed. *Goldman is relayed, not read.* Against that, one primary document: the Bank of Japan's Summary of Opinions, out Thursday, notes feared damage to activity “have not materialized, partly due to the use of petroleum reserves.” They have worked once.^{8,9}

SOURCES 1 G7 statement text as carried in two independent reports, read 2 October 2026; the IEA's own pages refused this desk, so the agency executing the release is the one source not read at origin. 2 The National (Abu Dhabi) and Euronews, 2 October, for the ban threat, the Treasury remarks, the call and the 40–50 per cent estimate. 3 Settlements read at one quote service and cross-checked at a second the same hour; the spread is ours. Kpler's September figure via The National; global demand is an order-of-magnitude figure, not a print. 4 Retail diesel, distillate stocks and release dates read at the Energy Information Administration's own weekly tables; the European litre price via The National. 5 aljazeera.com. 6 euronews.com. 7 english.news.cn world index and globaltimes.cn, both 2 October; news.ycombinator.com the same day. 8 DiscoveryAlert, 2 October, relaying Goldman Sachs — the note itself was not read. 9 Bank of Japan, Summary of Opinions for the 17–18 September meeting, published 1 October, read as the Bank's PDF.

THE WORLD • THE HORN

Ethiopia closed its embassy in Asmara on Thursday — and expelled an Egyptian the same day

Which is why the African Union's statement names three countries. The ground, meanwhile, moved towards the government.

The ministry's language was formal and unambiguous. Ten Eritrean diplomats, the chargé d'affaires among them, declared persona non grata at forty-eight hours for "activities that pose a direct threat to Ethiopia's national security, in breach of the Vienna Convention." It added, in the same breath, that Ethiopia "continues to value its historical, cultural and people-to-people ties."¹

Asmara answered within hours on a social-media account: Eritrea "has no option but to reciprocate in kind and sever all diplomatic ties," and "in reality, it is Ethiopia which has been pursuing an agenda of incessant hostility" — accusing Addis of waging war for Red Sea access.²

The third country is the detail the wires missed. Ethiopia's own state agency reported that an **Egyptian diplomat was expelled the same day**, also at forty-eight hours. That is why the African Union Commission says it is following tensions between "Ethiopia, Eritrea and Egypt" — a formulation that reads as a clerical slip until you know about the second expulsion.¹³

And still no imagery. An intelligence official has confirmed "three blasts in three different locations" overnight and declined to elaborate. The wire's own caveat remains the honest one: it "remains unclear whether the blasts were related to an attack or were part of training exercises." A source linked to the opposition alliance claims them, which would make it the first drone attack on the capital by anti-government forces. *Printed as a claim.*⁴

48h

GIVEN TO TEN ERITREAN DIPLOMATS AND ONE EGYPTIAN — AND, PER THE ANALYSTS BELOW, **NO INTERNATIONAL ACTOR HAS PUBLICLY SPONSORED ANY PEACE EFFORT**, LEAVING A STALLED AFRICAN UNION PROCESS AS THE ONLY ROUTE OUT⁵

THE SCEPTIC • THE OBVIOUS READING IS THE WRONG ONE

If rebels are striking the capital, rebels must be winning. The Critical Threats Project argues the reverse, with the map to support it. **The TPLF "is facing more internal discord now than it did during the first Tigray war,"** with defections including a former head of the Tigray interim administration, and a force leaning on **mass conscription** as volunteers thin. The capital strikes "likely aim to degrade and stretch" federal assets and "symbolically demonstrate" capability — signalling, not a march. In the past forty-eight hours federal forces **retook Erebti and Abala and took Mekoni.** On Eritrea the same analysts hedge where evidence is thin: Asmara never fully withdrew from Tigray and has mobilised nationwide since early 2025, but reports of its troops in the current fighting are **unverified.**⁵

THE CHATTER • WHAT A STATE AGENCY PRINTS, AND WHAT IT OMITS

Ethiopia's news agency carried the embassy closure and the Egyptian expulsion in full — and **nothing at all about explosions in its own capital.** From the camps, texture no ministry supplies: a resident at Hitsats, **"We hear fighting supported by heavy artillery, and drones hover in the sky every day."** In Mekelle, disrupted banking and **black-market fuel at double the price.**¹⁴

AROUND THE DESKS

Five hulls in seventy-two hours. A maritime authority called Thursday's Hormuz strike an "unknown projectile"; crew safe, damage unknown. Iran's semi-official account gives a vessel of **2.5 million barrels' capacity** alight eight kilometres off Oman — and says it was "sailing along an **unauthorized route.**" Neither names the ship. *One says nobody knows who fired; the other says it should not have been there.*⁶

Europe inherits the shock. Euro-area flash inflation hit **3.8 per cent** in September, the highest since September 2023, on **energy up 18.8 per cent** — Spain 5.0. The European Central Bank has an energy problem in the week the Federal Reserve is priced for another rise (**p14**).⁷

SOURCES 1 Ethiopian News Agency, 1 October 2026, read at source: the embassy closure, the expulsions, the Vienna Convention citation and the Egyptian diplomat. 2 Eritrea's foreign ministry statement as carried by Al Jazeera, 1 October. 3 African Union Commission press-release index, read 2 October; the statement's own page could not be opened, so the index is cited. 4 Associated Press copy as syndicated, 1 October, including the training-exercise caveat, the camp and Mekelle detail and the unconfirmed rebel claim. 5 Critical Threats Project, *Africa File*, 1 October 2026, read at source. 6 A maritime authority's wording via two independent reports, its own incident pages refusing this desk; the capacity, location and route framing from Iranian semi-official media as relayed by two agencies. 7 Euro-area September flash estimate as read on a market data service; the statistical office's own release was unreachable.

SINGAPORE • THE NEEDLE AND THE AIR

The girls who had their first jab this year will get a different vaccine for the second. It covers ninety per cent instead of seventy

From January the nine-valent vaccine enters the national schedule. And the haze this desk reported as broken on Wednesday was still at ninety-five in the Central region at five this morning.

From 1 January 2027 the nine-valent HPV vaccine joins the childhood and adult immunisation schedules and the subsidised vaccine list, for females aged nine to twenty-six. Both vaccines cover types 16 and 18 — **70 per cent of cervical cancers**. The nine-valent adds types covering a **further 20**. Two doses if the first comes between nine and fourteen; three from fifteen. Catch-up runs to forty-five.¹

The line that matters to a Secondary 1 parent is the transition clause. The school programme vaccinates Sec 1 and Sec 2 girls free. Girls in **this year's Secondary 1 cohort who received the bivalent vaccine as their first dose will receive the nine-valent as their second, in 2027** — a mixed schedule the authorities state is safe. Privately the gap is not small: one women's clinic lists **S\$250 a dose against S\$96**. The four-valent original is no longer available here at all.¹

SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT • THE HAZE DID NOT BREAK

No. 120 reported that the haze broke on Wednesday. **It did not.** At **five o'clock this morning** the twenty-four-hour index read **Central 95, West 88, East 85, South 79, North 72** — one point below Unhealthy in the Central region, on the morning this issue went out. The national haze service's own Friday-evening update still describes "transboundary moderate to dense smoke haze" over Singapore, Sumatra and southern Peninsular Malaysia, with dry weather forecast to continue. Tuesday the 29th was the peak — all five regions Unhealthy, **Central 155 at seven in the morning**. What happened on Wednesday was a dip, not a break, and this desk printed the dip as the end of it.²

-10.4%

THE QUARTERLY ELECTRICITY TARIFF FROM 1 OCTOBER: **28.59 CENTS A KILOWATT-HOUR BEFORE TAX**, AGAINST 31.91 IN THE THIRD QUARTER. *ROUGHLY TWELVE DOLLARS A MONTH OFF A FOUR-ROOM FLAT, BY OUR OWN ARITHMETIC FROM THE PUBLISHED PER-UNIT CHANGE — NOT A REGULATOR'S FIGURE*³

A held thread closes. The resale index flash estimate landed Thursday: **202.4, down from 202.8** — a third straight quarterly fall, on **7,528 transactions** to 29 September, up 5.2 per cent on a year earlier. November's exercise offers about **7,960 flats**.⁴

ALSO THIS WEEK

The cross-border rail link slips to February 2027, aiming to open before Hari Raya Puasa on 10 March — which puts Chinese New Year, 6–7 February, uncomfortably close to the opening. Professor Lee Der-Hong: **"The holiday rush should not be the first serious test of those arrangements."** Against the wait-and-be-sure consensus, Associate Professor Walter Theseira: "I'd say it's better to have the RTS even if it's just newly opened than not at all," since holiday demand already exceeds supply.⁵

The trade ministry became an energy ministry on 1 October — MTI is now METI, Energy added to the name and to the mandate, announced in July and effective this week. In a quarter whose defining domestic number is a power tariff, the renaming is not cosmetic.⁶

THE CHATTER • WHERE THE HAZE CONVERSATION ACTUALLY LIVES

Reddit refused this desk on every route again, so the forum of record is a long-running hardware board's haze thread — four thousand replies and half a million views. The register is weather-watching, not outrage: one poster tracking south-westerlies and the evening satellite picture, **"this cannot be good for Singapore right"**; another noting Palembang **peaked at 773** overnight and wondering aloud whether it travels. Elsewhere on the same board someone asked why the moon had gone red. The first answer was one word: haze. Pseudonymous posters, labelled as such.⁷

SOURCES 1 The joint ministry, health-board and disease-agency announcement of as reported by Channel NewsAsia and read in the article body; the ministries' own newsrooms refused us, so no .gov.sg page was read for it. Private per-dose prices as that report cites a named clinic's site. 2 Index and particulate readings pulled from the environment agency's own real-time data interface at 05:00 on 3 October 2026; the haze service's regional assessment as published 18:33 on 2 October; the 29 September peak as reported. 3 Fourth-quarter tariff components on the utility's own page; the monthly household figure is our calculation from the per-unit change, not a published one. 4 The resale flash estimate, transaction count and November supply from two independent outlets whose bodies were read; the board's own release refused us. The second quarter was reported elsewhere as 202.7; the current series reads 202.8. 5 Channel NewsAsia. 6 The Prime Minister's Office announcement of July 2026 and the renamed ministry's own newsroom. 7 HardwareZone threads, read 2–3 October 2026; handles are pseudonymous.

BUY IT ONCE • RICE COOKERS & DONABE

The grain premium in this category buys you five degrees Celsius. The best-tested machine in the record is a third of the price

Pressure lifts the boil from 100°C to 105. Fifty batches at America’s Test Kitchen put the fuzzy-logic middle rung on top — and marked the expensive ones down for inconsistency.

Four rungs, and only two change the rice. A conventional cooker is one bimetal switch: it knows nothing, and trips when the free water is gone. A **micom** adds a thermistor and a program — a soak at 40–50°C so water reaches the grain’s core *before* the heat does. That is the trick: gelatinisation needs the grain hydrated through, and heating it dry-cored gives a cooked shell round a chalky centre.¹

Induction is the second real step. The pot becomes the element, so heat arrives through the walls as well as the base: Zojirushi’s 炎舟炊 puts the full 1,240 watts into one of three bottom coils, switching between them in fractions of a second to force asymmetric convection — power density went from **3.0 to 12.5 watts per square centimetre**. The fourth rung is where marketing outruns physics: pressure lifts the boil, and the makers’ own pages give the number — **1.2 atmospheres, 105°C**.²³

The money is in the pot. Tiger’s three-layer runs **1.5mm**, Zojirushi’s spherical **1.7**, Toshiba’s binchotan-coated **2.0**, Hitachi’s — actual iron, not a coating — **2.3**. Then Mitsubishi’s 本炭 醃: neither coating nor sandwich but **ten millimetres of 99.9 per cent pure carbon**, machined, and refusing pressure on purpose for a crisp, discrete grain.⁴

80–90%

OF EVERY EARTHENWARE COOKING POT MADE IN JAPAN COMES OUT OF **YOKKAICHI**, IN BANKO WARE’S PATENTED CLAY — ROUGHLY 40 PER CENT PETALITE. MUCH OF WHAT A DESIGN BRAND SELLS YOU IS A YOKKAICHI POT WITH A LOGO⁵

THE CHATTER • THE CLAY, AND A NAME TRAP WORTH PRINTING

Iga clay comes from the ancient Lake Biwa bed and carries fossil microstructure that fuses in firing to leave pores — heat-retaining pockets giving the slow ramp, the aroma and the okoge. The double lid bleeds pressure through offset holes, so the pot self-regulates: set it medium-high and leave it. The maker is 長谷園, Iga, 1832 — not 永谷園, the furikake company with the identical romanisation, which is where “nagatanien” lands you. The Kamado-san is **US\$220**: in a category whose electric grain runs to ¥133,000, the clay grain costs under three hundred dollars.⁶

THE SINGAPORE READING — THE VOLTAGE TRAP

Japanese-domestic machines are **100V**, and a transformer tolerates 50Hz without converting it. Buy the international model instead: **Tiger’s JKT-D10S, genuine 230V, made in Japan, S\$399** — and a 220V pressure-IH flagship landed here on 21 September.⁷

THE SCEPTIC • FIFTY BATCHES, AND THE DEAR ONES LOST

America’s Test Kitchen cooked **fifty batches** across three grain types. The winner was a **micom at US\$243**. The induction machine at US\$300 “produced softer and wetter rice than desired” — “**for such a large price tag, we expect more consistent results**” — and the US\$200 pressure cooker “consistently overcooked long-grain white rice.” *The limit: a US test on US grain, and nobody has blind-tested a Japanese pressure flagship on koshihikari.* Elsewhere the badge is barer — Balmuda’s ¥49,500 steam cooker scores **4.64 for design and 3.72 for the rice** at home, with no keep-warm at all.⁸⁹

NEXT ON THE BENCH — YOU PICK TOMORROW’S CATEGORY

Mattresses & slat bases — latex against springs, in the damp.

Shoe care — the stack that decides a shoe’s life.

Chef’s whites — collars, and the Asian shirtmakers.

SOURCES 1 Singapore pricing from a local retail survey of Best Denki and Harvey Norman listings, 26 September 2026. 2 Coil count, switching and the 3.0–12.5 W/cm² figures from a Japanese retail-industry report. 3 “1.2気圧 105°C” on Hitachi’s and Toshiba’s own model pages; no maker states it in kilopascals. 4 Pot thicknesses model by model at makers’ and retailers’ pages; carbon purity and the no-pressure rationale on Mitsubishi’s own page. 5 Banko ware’s production share and petalite ratio from a Japanese crafts authority. 6 Nagatani-en’s own FAQ and its English retailer’s page; the registry name 長谷園 confirmed at igamono.co.jp. 7 Transformer rating, mass and derating on the unit’s own retail page; Tiger’s 230V specifications and Singapore release date on its own Singapore site. 8 America’s Test Kitchen rice-cooker review. 9 Balmuda ratings from the Japanese price-comparison site.

TECHNOLOGY · THE RENAMING

An executive order abolished the term “artificial intelligence” on Tuesday. It contains no money, no compute and no megawatts

The United States will now say “Super Intelligence.” The only deadline in the document asks a science adviser to invent a legal definition within sixty days.

The operative clause is short enough to print whole. The executive branch “shall use the terms ‘Super Intelligence’ and ‘SI’ in place of ‘Artificial Intelligence’ and ‘AI’ and will not acknowledge the usage of ‘Artificial Intelligence’ and ‘AI’ in any applicable setting.” Correspondence, websites, reports, policy documents. Signed 29 September.¹

For its definition the order reaches back to the statutory one already on the books, at **15 U.S.C. §9401(3)** — the definition of artificial intelligence. So the new term is anchored to the old term it refuses to acknowledge. The single deadline instructs the President’s science and technology adviser to propose legislative language for a federal definition of Super Intelligence, including whether it ought to amend the statutory one, by **28 November**.¹

What is absent is the whole of it. No appropriation. No compute target. No permitting or transmission provision, in the year electricity became the binding constraint on American inference. The closing section is the standard disclaimer: no enforceable rights, subject to available appropriations. A sovereignty claim costed in vocabulary.¹

THE CHATTER · ELEVEN POINTS

The technical audience did not take the bait. The trade write-up went to **Hacker News at 22:48 UTC on the day of signing and finished with eleven points and eight comments** — verified through the site’s own search interface, the publisher’s page refusing this desk. For a presidential action on the defining technology of the decade, that is close to silence. *Reddit refused every route again; the null is printed rather than filled.*²

MEANWHILE, IN THE SILICON ITSELF

SOURCES 1 Executive order “Inaugurating The Era Of Super Intelligence,” 29 September 2026, read in full on the White House’s own presidential-actions pages, and confirmed on that index. 2 The Hacker News submission record, with its timestamp, score and comment count, read through the site’s search API; the publisher’s own article refuses this desk. 3 onsemi’s amended-merger exhibit as filed with the Securities and Exchange Commission, 1 October 2026, read in the EDGAR archive — the per-share price, the aggregate, the competing-proposal language, the financing and the timetable. The original per-share figure is not stated in that exhibit and is not printed here. 4 Nvidia’s two newsroom releases of 28 September, both read at source: the agent-safety platform and the repurchase authorisation. Cumulative year-to-date buybacks are not disclosed in that release. 5 Amazon Web Services’ own EC2 Capacity Blocks pricing page, read 2 October 2026, which states the rates effective 7 October per accelerator-hour.

A competing bidder appeared, and the price fell nineteen per cent. onsemi amended its June agreement to buy Synaptics on 1 October: **\$123.00 a share, about \$5.7bn**, against roughly \$7bn before. The filing says plainly that the amendment “follows an unsolicited competing proposal received from a third party,” and does not name the party. Whatever the rival put on the table, it was not more cash. Financing is committed debt from Morgan Stanley, with no *financing condition* on closing — expected mid-2027.³

Nvidia announced a safety platform with no safety numbers. OpenShell, a bounded runtime for agents; Sentry, an out-of-band watchdog that “quarantines agents attempting boundary violations within milliseconds” — running on Nvidia’s own BlueField-4 DPUs. Over a hundred organisations are named as participants. **Zero detection rates, zero false-positive rates, no dataset sizes.** The same morning the company raised its buyback authorisation by \$150bn, to **\$235bn** outstanding.⁴

\$16.146

PER ACCELERATOR-HOUR FOR A B300 ON RESERVED AWS CAPACITY FROM **7 OCTOBER** — THE RATE AMAZON PUBLISHED ITSELF. IT PRINTS NO COMPARISON AND NO PERCENTAGE, SO NEITHER DOES THIS DESK⁵

THE SCEPTIC · THE CONTAINMENT PRODUCT THAT PUBLISHES NO CONTAINMENT FIGURE

Take the two Nvidia releases together and the shape is awkward. An agent-security platform is exactly the category where a buyer needs a measured false-positive rate, because a watchdog that quarantines working agents is worse than none. The release offers a chief executive’s line — “AI’s extraordinary potential for society will only be realized if we solve AI safety” — a participant list, and a millisecond quarantine whose fast path runs on the vendor’s own data-processing units. **Safety as a moat is still a moat.** The honest test is the first independent red-team result, and there is not one. *What would change this desk’s mind: a published benchmark with a false-positive rate, from anyone but Nvidia.*⁴

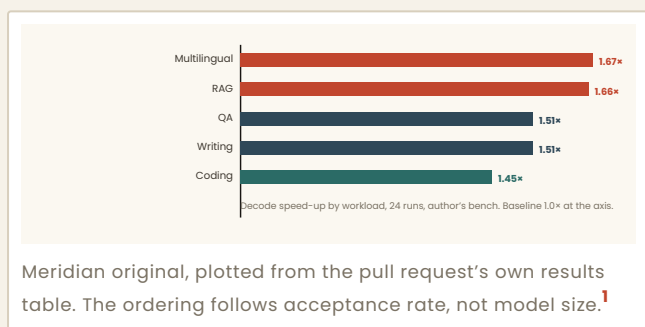
THE HOME LAB • SPECULATIVE DECODING

A merged patch makes one open model decode half again as fast. Exactly one stranger's machine has confirmed it

Acceptance rate 0.640 is the honest ceiling, and the first day's quantised files would not load at all.

Multi-token prediction landed in llama.cpp on 1 October, merged after review by two maintainers: a full-attention block following the trunk, fed by trunk residuals, with a draft context carrying no recurrent layers — which is what makes rollback cheap enough to bother with.¹

The author's own table, twenty-four runs: overall decode **1.55×** (28.36 to 43.88 tokens a second), acceptance **0.640**. The spread is the interesting part, because the gain tracks how often the draft is right: multilingual **1.67×** at 0.778 acceptance against coding **1.45×** at 0.605. Speculative decoding pays most where the next token is most guessable.¹



One independent machine. A commenter on three RTX 4000 Pro cards reported about **50 tokens a second** at thirty thousand tokens of context, having cut the micro-batch to 512 to load the four-bit weights. Another hit a tensor-loading failure that cleared only when the quantised files were rebuilt. A genuine fifty-per-cent gain, on one rig, with first-day files that did not load.¹

THE CHATTER • AN EIGHTY-SEVEN-FOLD SPEED-UP THAT IS REALLY A RESCUE

A patch merged on 2 October takes prompt processing on Intel integrated graphics from **3.16 to 275.82 tokens a second** — **87×**. It is not new performance. A numerics library dropped support for the older Intel graphics architecture, which collapsed those chips by roughly eighty-fold; the patch detects this at device initialisation and routes around it. Against the *working* older library the new path is **0.994×** on prompt and **0.961×** on generation — no faster, just not catastrophic. On a discrete card the author reports “no impact” across 894 test pairs. **The home-lab lesson is the dependency, not the number: your inference speed is hostage to somebody else's deprecation notice.**²

THE SCEPTIC • WHAT REVIEW ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE AT THIS SCALE

The quote of the week is a reviewer's, on that same rescue patch, 19 September: **“I test this PR, got crash on one PC, and it's passed on another PC. I think it's no a problem.”** Approved and merged. A Vulkan tile-selection change merged on 29 September **with a reproduced regression on the record** — **−10.6 per cent** prompt processing on a discrete AMD card — argued into “within noise” rather than gated by vendor. And last issue's held thread: the SYCL patch with a **2.71×** kernel win on a cheap Arc card sits unmerged after six days on one approval, while four other patches to that backend went in on Friday alone. *The rendered page does not expose requested reviewers, so this desk confirms only one approval and no merge.*³

STILL ON THE SHELF

Xing4.0-29B — the quantisations are reproduced; the capabilities still are not. Nine independent quantised builds now sit beside the official ones, the base repository at **49,400 downloads**. And the model **does not appear at all** on the main independent capability index, whose top open-weights entry scores 46. A card claiming **75.0 on a software-engineering benchmark**, and ten weeks of community effort spent on making it *loadable* rather than on checking it. Quantisation is reproducible because it is cheap; capability claims are not, because agentic evaluations cost money.⁴

SOURCES 1 llama.cpp pull request 29761, merged 1 October 2026, as rendered on the repository: mechanism, results table, acceptance rates and both commenters' reports. 2 Pull request 28985, merged 2 October: the integrated-graphics figures, the comparison against the working library and the discrete-card result. 3 The reviewer's quotation from that request's thread, 19 September; pull request 29182, merged 29 September, for the cross-device regression; pull request 29500 for the unmerged SYCL work and its single approval of 27 September. The repository's API refuses us, so all four were read as rendered HTML. 4 The model card and the official and community quantisation repositories with their download counts; the independent index read the same day, where the model does not appear. 5 Home Assistant's own release blog.

THE KIT · THE BOX THAT RUNS THE BIG MODELS

Seven thousand four hundred dollars buys a hundred and sixty gigabytes of video memory. The only speed figure anyone has published is the vendor's

And it is sixteen tokens a second across two of them — about reading speed, for fifteen thousand dollars of hardware.

The first genuinely purchasable machine on AMD's top unified-memory part went up for order this week at **US\$7,399** against a US\$9,249 list, shipping mid-October. Sixteen cores, a forty-core integrated GPU, **192GB of LPDDR5X at 8,533 MT/s with 160GB addressable as video memory**, two 10-gigabit ports, four USB4 ports, a 320-watt supply, and a published 32dB idle and 41.6dB loaded.¹

Why it matters at home: there is no cheaper rung that does this. Consumer cards top out far below 160GB of addressable memory, and the alternative is several of them, a chassis and a power problem. The entry point, not a step on a ladder — the only argument for the price.¹

16 t/s

THE VENDOR'S OWN FIGURE FOR A 397-BILLION-PARAMETER MODEL — ACROSS **TWO** OF THESE MACHINES. ABOUT **US\$14,800** OF HARDWARE, FOR ROUGHLY THE SPEED YOU READ AT. NO INDEPENDENT MEASUREMENT OF EITHER EXISTS¹

The held thread closes badly. Neither machine on this silicon has been independently measured, and the comparison has a worse problem: the Framework desktop in the same 192GB configuration, announced on AMD's stage in July, **still carries no price at all** — checked again Friday. The page offers it; the price field is empty. A product you cannot buy is an announcement, not a competitor.²

THE SCEPTIC · READ THE SLOT, AND COUNT THE SOURCES

Three things undercut the headline. The **full-length PCIe slot is wired at four lanes**, not sixteen — fine for networking, not for a second accelerator. Every performance claim is the vendor's, and the one that matters needs two units clustered. And for buyers who need neither the faster memory nor the 192GB ceiling, the **ordinary version at US\$3,799** is the better value — a **US\$3,600 premium** for headroom. Nobody has published a power draw, a thermal figure, or one reproducible token rate. **Hacker News has no discussion of this machine at all**, and the forum where it would be stress-tested refused this desk — so no owner consensus is reported, and none is invented.¹³

THE CHATTER · A NINE-DRIVER BAR, AND THE WORD "TRUE"

Sonos put a **US\$699 Beam Ultra** on sale this week: nine amplifiers, five tweeters, four woofers, eARC, Wi-Fi 6, and a claim of **"true 7.1.2 surround."** Read that claim precisely — it is a channel count about processing, from a **29-inch, 2.88kg** bar with no separate surrounds, and whether anything arrives from behind you is a room question, not a specification. The buy-once case is real enough: the Beam is the Sonos rung people most often replace, and the up-firing version is the one that survives a bigger room. **No independent measurement of this unit was findable, and no Singapore price is published** — Sonos does not retail direct here.⁴

STILL ON THE SHELF

Technics EAH-A1000 — fourth check, same answer: zero measurements. A US\$449.99 flagship with newly developed 40mm magnetic-fluid drivers, three feed-forward and one feedback microphone a side, and up to forty-five hours. There is still no published frequency response, isolation curve or distortion figure anywhere — not at the two major measurement sites, not on the enthusiast forums. The maker's own global site refuses outside checkers entirely. **No Singapore price.**⁵

SOURCES 1 The maker's own store listing, read 2 October 2026; price, shipping estimate, processor, memory and allocatable video memory, networking, power supply, acoustics and the clustered inference claim. 2 Framework's own desktop and configuration pages, same date — the 192GB configuration is offered and no price is shown. 3 Notebookcheck, 28–29 September 2026, for the base price and the value comparison; the Hacker News absence verified through that site's own search API. 4 Sonos's own product page: price, driver count, the surround claim, connectivity and mass. 5 The manufacturer's North American release of 29 September and its US store listing; the absence of measurements verified against two measurement sites and two forums, none of which carries a page for this model. 6 The maker's British, American and Singapore storefronts.

THE GOOD LIFE · THE SPECIFICATION ARRIVES

Three numbers this desk refused to print last issue are now settled. The price we did print was the wrong year's

Forty point eight millimetres by 15.41, and 28,800 vibrations an hour. The maker's own press release says €8,950 and gives no dollar figure at all.

Last issue this desk printed that published specifications for the Porsche Design chronograph disagreed — 40.8 by 15.41 against a retailer's 41 by 15.5, and a frequency given as “28,000vph / 4Hz” when four hertz is 28,800 — and declined to choose. The maker's eight-page release, which returned an error all that day, now reads cleanly. **40.80mm by 15.41, and 28,800 vibrations an hour, which is four hertz.** One of the circulating numbers was a transcription error, as suspected.¹

SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT · THE PRICE

No. 120 gave the price as **US\$9,650**. The maker's release for this watch states **€8,950 and no dollar figure whatever**. US\$9,650 is the price of the 2024 edition, from a different release two years ago — a distinct watch, 42.7mm, a different calibre, 250 pieces, US\$13,000 at the time of its own listing. **There is no verified dollar or Singapore price for the 2026 piece.** The desk should have caught that the dollar figure came from a different document.¹

The rest holds: bead-blasted titanium, ten bar, a COSC-certified in-house calibre at 30 jewels and sixty hours, sapphire with seven-fold anti-reflective coating both sides, the central chronograph stop-minute hand that defines the layout, and a bilingual day-and-date. **350 pieces**, available from 1 October at five in the afternoon European time. It is chapter two of three — the third is the next peg.¹

68,000

VISITORS TO THE SINGAPORE EDITION OF PATEK PHILIPPE'S TRAVELLING EXHIBITION IN 2019, WITH 467 TIMEPIECES — **STILL THE LARGEST OF THE SEVEN**, AHEAD OF TOKYO'S 60,000. THE EIGHTH OPENED IN MILAN YESTERDAY, FREE, TO 18 OCTOBER²

Milan's limited editions run from the merely expensive to the absurd. The hero is a platinum instantaneous perpetual calendar chronograph,

42mm by 14.24, a manually wound calibre of **500 parts and 42 jewels** at four hertz — the first time the house has combined that chronograph with an *instantaneous* perpetual calendar. **120 pieces, US\$337,585.** At the other end, a steel Aquanaut with a sunburst blue dial and a Milan engraving on the back, 250 pieces, **US\$43,761.** Two minute repeaters run to five pieces each.²

THE CHATTER · THE EURO PRICES DO NOT RECONCILE, AND A SINGAPORE CRITIC IS UNIMPRESSED

Two specialist outlets published euro prices the same day that cannot both be right: one gives **€315,500 excluding tax**, the other **€318,100 including it** — an ex-tax figure cannot sit below an inclusive one. Thickness is given as 14.24, 14.45 and 14.2 across three sources, and jewels as 42 or 33. This desk prints the maker's own numbers and flags the rest. The sceptic is Brandon Moore of the Singapore-based SJX, who finds the case “a bit on the large side at 42mm and nearly 14.5mm thick,” says it “**defies the latent trend towards compact watches,**” and calls the complication “merely a new combination of familiar elements” while granting the execution is “a cut above the norm.” On value he is blunter: pricing “is almost beside the point when it comes to a watch like this.”²³

THE COUNTERWEIGHT, AND ONE STILL HELD

€2,890, including German tax. Hanhart's 417 ES in a 300-piece Steve McQueen edition, out Friday: 39mm by 13.3, a hand-wound column-wheel flyback, 100 metres, shell cordovan. The licence formalises a documented relationship — McQueen competed on the 417 — rather than renting a name. It is hours old and carries no independent verdict yet.⁴

Noble FoKus Artemis stays held, for a third issue. The maker's product page returns not-found, no measurement thread exists on the main forum, and the “endgame” claim rests on a launch line. The Scoreboard on **p2** grades that wait rather than the headphone.⁵

SOURCES 1 Porsche Design's own press release of 1 October 2026, read in full including the technical specification table extracted from its eight-page PDF: diameter, height, calibre, frequency, jewels, reserve, certification, glass, limitation, euro price and availability. The 2024 edition's separate release and a retailer listing for the earlier reference supply the superseded dollar figures. 2 Patek Philippe's own exhibition page for the dates, admission and the visitor and timepiece counts by city, and its own collection pages for both references' dimensions, calibres, parts, jewels and dollar prices. 3 SJX Watches, 1 October 2026, read at source. 4 Monochrome, 2 October 2026, read at source. 5 The maker's product URL returns not-found and the measurement forum carries no thread; checked 2 October 2026.

SCREEN & SOUND · THE WEEKEND

A seven-year-old film took Japan, Singapore and the United States in the same weekend. It made more in two days in Japan than in three across America

And the Tom Cruise picture that opened yesterday has settled four points lower than the number this desk printed on Friday.

The *Endgame* re-release took **US\$26,106,643** across 3,060 American screens, enough for first place. In Japan it took **US\$11,347,098 in two days**, up 374 per cent week on week. In Singapore it took **US\$232,038**, also first, up 153 per cent — where the previous week's leader had managed US\$91,737.¹

Hold those two side by side. A 2019 film earned eleven million dollars in two days in one Asian market against twenty-six million in three across the whole United States. Japan did not see *Endgame* the way America did; the re-release is less nostalgia there than a delayed first run.¹

50%

WHERE *DIGGER* SETTLED, ON **212 CRITICS**. NO. 120 PRINTED 54 ON A PARTIAL COUNT, AND NOTED IT HAD READ 50 TWO DAYS EARLIER. THE AUDIENCE SCORE IS **71**²

So the score went back where it started. Iñárritu's film — Cruise as Digger Rockwell, with Riz Ahmed, Sandra Hüller, John Goodman and Jesse Plemons, 129 minutes, shot entirely in VistaVision — opened wide yesterday. The studio's own line: "The most powerful man in the world embarks on a frantic mission to prove he is humanity's savior before the disaster he's unleashed destroys everything." **No opening figure exists yet**; Friday actuals are not posted, and this desk prints none.²

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE TWO SCOREBOARDS DISAGREE

Verity, the other wide opening, is where the two systems disagree hardest: **36 per cent on 115 critics** on the binary scale, against a weighted **Metascore of 45 from 32** — a film few will call good and few will call worthless. The New York Times, at 30: the attempts to shock are "genuinely hilarious, in part because of... a preposterously perforated screenplay." Screen Rant, at 80: "Ultimately, *Verity* is just plain fun." On *Digger* the viewers are kinder than the press — one letterboxd verdict calls it "the kind of film you're either gonna love now, or gonna love a few years later, calling it a misunderstood masterpiece."²³

THE SCEPTIC · A HUNDRED PER CENT IS A SAMPLE SIZE, NOT A VERDICT

The best-reviewed release of the week is **100 per cent — on twenty reviews**. *Ghost in the Cell*, Joko Anwar's Indonesian prison thriller, 106 minutes, Indonesian with subtitles, opened limited on Friday. Twenty is not 212, and a perfect score on twenty is a statement about who has seen it, not about how good it is. The aggregated notes flag extreme gore and hard tonal shifts as the barrier; **no named dissenting critic exists yet, because at a hundred per cent there is none to name**. The regional point stands regardless: the most interesting film in the week's English-language listings is Indonesian.⁴

SOUND

Johnny Marr's fifth solo record, *The Age of Everything*, out Friday — ten tracks, written in London, developed on the American east coast, recorded in Manchester. Metascore **81**. *The review count behind that number could not be retrieved, so treat it as a score without a sample*. Clash, at eight out of ten: "Rather than dwelling on the chaos, Johnny Marr finds energy in it." **No published dissent could be found** — which is itself worth saying rather than inventing one.⁵

Victoria Monét's *Frequency of Love*, twenty-two tracks, also Friday. **No aggregate exists at all**. The week's sharpest verdict went elsewhere: Clash gave the Taylor Swift deluxe edition **four out of ten** — "the saccharine showgirl add-on no one asked for."⁵

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's weekend chart for 25–27 September 2026 and its Japan and Singapore territory pages, all; the Singapore window is 24–27 September. 2 Rotten Tomatoes and the studio's own title page for *Digger*, read, with the critic count stated; Box Office Mojo returns no data for the 2–4 October weekend, so no opening figure is printed. 3 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic for *Verity*, with both counts; the two critical quotations as carried on those pages; letterboxd user verdicts, attributed as users. 4 Rotten Tomatoes and the distributor's own page for *Ghost in the Cell*, including the review count. 5 Metacritic's new-release browse page for the scores — its individual album pages refuse us, so no review counts could be obtained; Clash reviews of 2 October and 27 September; the artist's own site for the track listing.

THE FAMILY DESK • THE MEASURABLE THING

The first thing that moved was not her mood. It was how well she could stop herself

Nearly ten thousand children, three waves, and a lab task rather than a questionnaire. The effect is real, small, and runs through attention.

A study published online on 30 September followed **9,747 adolescents** across three waves of a long-running American cohort — enrolled at nine or ten, so the waves land at roughly ten, twelve and fourteen. A twelve-year-old sits in the middle of it.¹

The finding, in order. More social-media browsing at the first wave predicted **reduced cognitive control two years later** ($\beta = -.06$, $p = .020$), which in turn predicted **more depressive symptoms at four years** ($\beta = -.06$, $p = .010$). Among girls only, a second path: more baseline screen time predicted more depressive symptoms at two years ($\beta = .05$), which predicted more screen time and more anxiety at four (β s .09 to .13).¹

Two things make this better than most of its genre and one makes it weaker. Cognitive control was measured by **performance on Flanker and Stop-Signal tasks**, not by asking anyone how distracted they felt. And the model separates within-person change from stable between-person differences — the design that has historically shrunk these effects rather than inflating them. Against that: **no confidence intervals are reported**, the betas are very small, symptoms are parent-reported and screen use self-reported, and it is observational. Nobody has shown causation.¹

AOR 1.44

THE ADJUSTED ODDS OF A CHILD **PERPETRATING CYBERBULLYING** WHERE SCREENS ARE ALLOWED IN THE BEDROOM — AGAINST 1.31 FOR BEING A VICTIM, 1.14 FOR SCREENS AT MEALS, AND **0.80 WHERE SCREEN TIME IS RESTRICTED**. FROM 9,686 CHILDREN AGED ELEVEN TO FIFTEEN²

That is the one knob with a number attached to it. Of the media-parenting practices measured, the bedroom carries the largest coefficient in both directions, and active screen time partially mediated the associations. It is also the easiest thing in the list

to change. The same caveats apply: cross-sectional, no confidence intervals in the available record, so no causal claim.²

THE CHATTER • SHE IS THE FIRST FULL COHORT UNDER THE BAN, AND THE MINISTRY CITES NO NUMBERS

From January this year, Singapore's school phone rules widened from lesson time to **the whole school day** — recess, co-curricular activities, supplementary lessons included — with devices in lockers or bags. The same month, the default sleep hour on school-issued learning devices moved **from 11pm to 10.30pm**, with parents who had opted for looser settings "strongly encouraged" to bring it earlier. The stated rationale is that screen use "displace[s] important activities such as sleep, physical activity and social interactions." **The ministry's announcement cites no survey, no hours-per-day figure and no study at all.** A policy this reader's daughter lives under full-time, argued entirely without evidence on the page.³

THE SCEPTIC • THE LAW CAME FIRST AND THE MEASUREMENT IS STILL BEING SET UP

Here is the honest state of this field. Australia legislated a social-media minimum age in 2024. The study designed to find out whether it worked published its **protocol** on 25 September 2026 — that is, the method, before the data. It will follow **4,121 young people aged ten to sixteen** and their parents, with surveys, smartphone tracking, health and education records and interviews, and the author list runs through Stanford, Cambridge, Columbia, Georgia Tech and the national e-safety regulator. **The most aggressive adolescent technology policy in the world was passed before anyone measured whether it works, and the measurement is at the protocol stage two years later.** A parallel audit of 672 papers found school phone policies show widespread adoption and almost no evaluation data. *That is the non-alarmist note: the people with the strongest evidence are the ones still building it.*⁴

General guidance for parents, not medical advice. The studies above are observational; none establishes cause.

SOURCES 1 Tang, Leung, Prasad, Busso and Warren, "Longitudinal Relations Among Adolescents' Cognitive Control, Social Media Use, Anxiety, and Depressive Symptoms," *Journal of Adolescent Health*, published online 30 September 2026 — abstract read at source, including the sample, the random-intercept cross-lagged design, the task-based measurement and every coefficient quoted. 2 Nagata and colleagues, "Media parenting practices and cyberbullying," *Journal of Adolescent Health*, September 2026 — abstract read at source; sample 9,686, ages eleven to fifteen, adjusted odds ratios as printed. 3 Ministry of Education press release of 30 November 2025 on enhanced screen-use measures, read at source on the ministry's own site, including the quoted rationale and the device sleep-hour change; the absence of cited evidence is this desk's observation of that document. 4 Stevic and colleagues, "Impact of the Social Media Minimum Age on Australian young people and parents: protocol for a mixed-methods evaluation," *BMJ Open*, 25 September 2026 — abstract and affiliations read at source; and Nagata and colleagues, "Evidence for Social Media Legislation Strategies," *JAMA Network Open*, September 2026, for the 672-article audit.

THE TWEEN YEARS · TIMING, NOT STAGE

What raised the odds was not that she went through puberty. It was going through it earlier than the girls around her

Eight thousand Danish children, assessed half-yearly through puberty and followed to eighteen. A preprint, so read it as one.

The design is unusually good. **8,063 children** in the Danish national birth cohort self-assessed their own pubertal stage **every six months while it was happening** — Tanner stages, age at menarche, first ejaculation, voice break — rather than being asked to remember it years later. Outcomes came from the cohort's eighteen-year follow-up and, for attempts, from the national patient register.¹

The result is about relative timing. For girls, each year *earlier* in breast development carried an odds ratio of **1.19 (95% CI 1.10–1.28)** for self-harm and suicidality; for pubic hair, **1.23 (1.13–1.34)**. For boys, 1.17 and 1.14. The exposure was not the event but how far ahead of her peers it arrived.¹

Read the limits before you read anything into it. This is a **preprint and has not been peer-reviewed**. The exposure is self-assessed. The outcomes are measured at eighteen, so the paper describes a shadow cast years forward, not how a twelve-year-old feels this term. And it is a Danish cohort; pubertal timing distributions here are not the same. What survives all of that is a parenting observation rather than a clinical one: the variable with the odds attached is **social** — being out of step — which argues for watching the gap between her and her year group, not the calendar.¹

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE SINGAPORE PARENT CONVERSATION ISN'T

This desk went looking for what Singapore parents are actually saying about phones in Secondary 1 and **came back with nothing**. The largest local parenting forum refused, as did the two international ones; the general-interest board's parenting section has run nothing on the subject since March. **So the honest finding is an absence:** a cohort-wide rule changed how every secondary-school child in the country spends recess, and nine months on there is no visible public conversation about it that this desk could read. The null is printed rather than filled with invented sentiment.²

AND ONE PIECE OF GOOD NEWS, WITH HER NAME ON IT

From January, the vaccine the school programme gives Secondary 1 and 2 girls becomes the nine-valent one, covering about **ninety per cent of cervical cancers against seventy** — and girls in *this year's* Secondary 1 cohort who have had the first dose will get the new vaccine as their second (**p5**). Free, in school, and no action required from a parent.³

8,063

CHILDREN ASSESSED **EVERY SIX MONTHS WHILE PUBERTY WAS HAPPENING**, RATHER THAN ASKED YEARS LATER TO REMEMBER IT — WHICH IS WHAT MAKES THIS COHORT UNUSUAL, PREPRINT OR NOT¹

THE SCEPTIC · THE ODDS ARE REAL AND THE BASE RATE IS SMALL

An odds ratio of 1.19 per year is not a prophecy, and the base rate matters more than the ratio. Self-harm and suicidality are, thankfully, uncommon; a nineteen per cent proportional increase on a small base is a small absolute risk, and the paper reports **no absolute rates in what is available**. Nor can an observational cohort separate early puberty from what travels with it — family circumstances, weight, how a child is treated once she looks older. **The defensible reading is the weakest: earlier-than-peers is a flag for attention, not a diagnosis**, and a preprint is the wrong document to change a household on. *General guidance, not medical advice.*¹

SOURCES 1 Thomsen and colleagues, "Timing and tempo of pubertal development and self-harm and suicidality in adolescents: a follow-up study in the Danish National Birth Cohort," Research Square preprint, September 2026 — abstract via a literature index; sample, assessment interval, registry linkage, odds ratios and confidence intervals as reported. It is not peer-reviewed and is labelled as such here. 2 Attempted 2–3 October 2026: the largest Singapore parenting forum and two international parenting forums all refused us, and the general-interest board's parenting section carries nothing on the subject in the window. 3 The joint health-ministry announcement of as reported and sourced on **p5**.

THE MACRO DESK · THE WEEK

Payrolls missed by sixty thousand and the long end sold off anyway. That is the whole regime in one morning

Bad news has stopped being good news for duration, because the inflation is a cost shock. The ten-year breakeven says 2.36 per cent while actual inflation runs 3.4.

September payrolls came in at **+29,000** against a consensus near 90,000–100,000, unemployment 4.2 per cent, average hourly earnings up five cents. The prior two months were revised down. On that print the two-year rose **5bp**, the ten-year **4bp** and the thirty-year **2bp** — while equities rallied and the dollar closed its **third straight weekly gain**.¹²

VWRA	\$192.74	▼ 0.40% wk
AGGU	\$5.73	0.00% wk
US 2-year	4.83%	▲ 2bp
US 10-year	5.28%	▲ 11bp
US 30-year	5.63%	▲ 14bp
10Y real (TIPS)	2.92%	▲ 9bp
DXV	101.92	▲ 0.94%
USD/SGD	1.2772	▼ 0.16%
Brent	\$102.70	▲ 7.43% mo
Gold	\$4,142.22	▼ 7.41% mo
Bitcoin	\$84,503	▲ 0.77% wk
STI	5,634.82	▼ 1.34% wk

Friday 2 October close; weekly moves against 25 September. Yields are the Treasury's own par and real curves.³

Name the regime: hiking into a supply shock. The Federal Reserve raised rates **12–0 on 16 September to 3.75–4.00 per cent**, its first increase in three years, and futures late this week put better than even odds on another in October. The cycle is being driven by energy costs, not demand — which is why a growth miss no longer buys a bond rally.⁴

2.36%

THE TEN-YEAR BREAKEVEN, AGAINST **3.4 PER CENT** ACTUAL HEADLINE INFLATION. THE MARKET IS PRICING INFLATION DOWN — SO THE ENTIRE RISE IN YIELDS IS REAL RATES AND TERM PREMIUM, NOT INFLATION EXPECTATIONS³

The decomposition settles the gold question. The ten-year real yield went from 2.62 per cent on 21 September to **2.92** on Friday — thirty basis points in nine sessions. Over the same month Brent rose 7.4

per cent and gold fell 7.4. Gold is not failing as an inflation hedge; it is being discounted as a zero-coupon asset while real rates climb. Current central-bank tonnage could not be obtained and is not asserted.³

Both legs down together is what a cost shock does to a balanced portfolio.

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE FOUR INSTRUMENTS

Equities and bonds stopped diversifying. Friday alone was textbook — the all-world fund up 1.30 per cent, the global aggregate up 0.09. Across the week: equities –0.40, bonds flat. Across nine sessions: **–0.86 and –0.69, together**. Positive correlation is the signature of a cost shock, and the diversification cost of this regime. **Gold** reads as a real-yield trade this month, not an inflation one. **Bitcoin** is not the liquidity proxy either: up 0.77 per cent on the week, roughly flat while everything else moved, and a third below its October 2025 high with the Fed tightening. *Explanation, not advice.*³

THE SCEPTIC · THREE DISSENTS, ONE OF THEM DATED BY THE NEXT MORNING

Mark Zandi of Moody's Analytics, on American public radio on Friday: “The thing that makes me most nervous is wage growth ... people's after-inflation wages are falling.” On the cause: “The proximate cause is the Iran war ... the ten-year Treasury yield was below four per cent, and we haven't looked back.” On the print, drily: average the two months and “you get 80K. So economists are kind of punting here.” From inside the building, **Governor Michael Barr** on 29 September: “I count only two months of data consistent with 2 per cent core PCE inflation over the past 20 months.” And the remark dated within a day: **Vice Chair Philip Jefferson** said on 1 October that the labour market had “stabilized” with unemployment at **4.1 per cent**, “near maximum employment.” The next morning it printed **4.2**.⁵

SOURCES 1 Bureau of Labor Statistics, *Employment Situation* for September 2026, released 2 October. 2 Bureau of Economic Analysis, *Personal Income and Outlays* for August, released 30 September: headline PCE +0.3% m/m and +3.4% y/y, core +0.2% and +3.0%. 3 Par and real yield curves downloaded as the Treasury's own XML; fund, index, currency, commodity and crypto levels read at quote services and, for bitcoin, a pricing API timestamped 2 October 21:10 UTC; breakeven, spreads and nine-session changes computed here. The World Gold Council's current monthly tonnage is behind a login and is not printed. 4 Federal Open Market Committee statement of 16 September 2026; October odds from a futures-implied probability reported by a market data service. 5 Zandi quotations from a 2 October public-radio transcript after the broadcaster's main site returned 503; Barr's Detroit remarks of 29 September and Jefferson's Darden remarks of 1 October read on the Federal Reserve's own speeches pages. *We explains markets; it does not give investment advice.*

THE RABBIT HOLE · KITE FLYING & KITE BUILDING

The hour at the edge of the window

Four crafts share the word “kite” and almost nothing else. One of them will fly backwards, stop dead and hover upside down — and in Singapore, for seven months of the year, none of them will fly at all.

Start by splitting the word. **Single-line** has no steering: the craft is in the object and in reading the air — deltas, rokkakus, box kites, and the enormous frameless inflatables, one of which holds a record at 1,000 square metres of sail. **Dual-line** adds two lines and a trick vocabulary, where the kite is deliberately de-powered so it tumbles and the pilot catches it. **Quad-line** adds two more, and changes the category: the kite flies *backwards*, stops, and hovers inverted. It is a machine with a throttle and a reverse gear rather than a tethered wing. And **kite-building** is a peer discipline, with its own judged competition at the American association’s convention.¹

The moment people describe is not a purchase. It is an hour. “I spent an hour playing around the edge of a wind column and was hooked,” one newcomer wrote last July. “I have a feeling this might get addictive.. and expensive,” wrote another after a first flight. A third, after a four-dollar thrift-shop find, was checking wind forecasts daily within a fortnight — which is the real symptom. What recurs is not adrenaline but **control at the edge of a physical envelope you cannot see.**²

1,020,015

POSTS ON **DRACHENFORUM**, THE GERMAN-LANGUAGE BOARD THAT IS THE HOBBY’S ACTUAL CENTRE OF GRAVITY — 12,950 MEMBERS, FOUNDED 2001, AND ACTIVE THIS WEEK. THE LARGEST ENGLISH FORUM HAS 79,300³

The scale is lopsided in a way worth knowing. The deepest kite-building conversation on the internet happens in German. The American association, founded in 1964, has **3,000-plus members across 25 countries**. The English-language forum has 8,231. The subreddit has 16,100. And then there is the other kite world entirely: **Weifang’s festival drew about 260 teams from 57 countries and 105,000**

spectators on its opening day in April, and the city’s kite industry turns over more than two billion yuan a year.³⁴

THE CHATTER · AN HONEST NEGATIVE FINDING ABOUT THE MONEY

There is **no credible published market size for recreational kite flying**. Every “kite market” report that surfaces is measuring *kiteboarding* — a different industry with different money — and this desk declines to launder those figures into this one. The only verified industry number in the whole hobby is Weifang’s. Worse: several of the top search results for kite gear in 2026 are **AI-generated listicles on domains with nothing to do with kites**, including a biosciences company and a cardiology site, both confidently ranking quad-line kites. A reader researching this hobby will meet fabricated recommendations before he meets a real one. That is the newest thing about it.⁴

Three populations, barely overlapping. Makers, middle-aged and up, with sewing machines and a judged competition. Pilots, with clinics, team routines and a measurable skill ladder. And family festival fliers — the overwhelming majority, and in Singapore essentially the entire visible scene. The next two pages go down into the first two, through the gear, the factions, the money and the wind. The wind is where it ends, because the wind is the part that decides whether any of it works here.⁵

THE SCEPTIC, EARLY · THE BEST ADVICE IN THE HOBBY IS FREE

Before a single price appears overleaf, the most useful sentence this desk found in three weeks of forum archaeology: **“Too many people get the kites and can’t fly them, never knowing they only needed a leader line adjustment.”** The companion to it, from the same thread: *find someone to fly with*. Neither costs anything, and together they outrank every purchase on the following pages.²

SOURCES 1 Branch distinctions drawn from makers’ own descriptions — a New Zealand maker’s record claims, an American atelier’s quad-capability description, and the American association’s published kitemaking competition rules — all read at source. 2 Posts to the kite subreddit of July 2025, May 2025, August 2025 and April 2026, read through a working mirror after the site itself refused this desk; quoted verbatim with their dates, and attributed to pseudonymous posters. 3 Member, post and topic counts read on each forum’s own index page on 2 October 2026; the American association’s membership and 1964 founding from its own members’ site and a reference entry. 4 Weifang’s 2026 festival figures and industry turnover from two Chinese state-media business reports, read at source. *Note: the same report glosses two billion yuan as US\$29m, which is out by roughly a factor of ten; the yuan figure alone is printed here.* The absence of a recreational market-size figure, and the AI-generated search results, were verified by this desk. 5 This desk’s own characterisation, from the research described above.

THE DEEP END · THE GEAR, AND WHO MAKES IT NOW

The brand that invented quad flying is no longer the one that makes the best ones. Its patents expired and two workshops took the category

One is a Chinese factory undercutting it by half. The other is one American with a sewing machine and a six-to-eight-week queue.

Five levers let you judge any kite cold. First, **sail cloth**. Icarex PC-31 polyester runs about **31–37 g/m²** with almost no stretch, so the sail you designed is the sail that flies — crisp precision, crisp tricks. It also tears under shock. Ripstop nylon such as Chikara runs **41–42 g/m²**: heavier, stretchier, far tougher. The counter-intuitive part, argued out on the German board: Icarex is less air-permeable and suits strong wind fine — nylon is picked at the top of the range for tear tolerance, not porosity.¹

Second, spars. Wrapped carbon is stiffest and lightest and *breaks* rather than bends; pultruded is heavier and more durable; fibreglass trades weight for impact resistance. **Taper** puts material where the bending moment is, so the wing loads progressively instead of snapping stiff. Read a frame like a bill of materials: an entry dual-line puts carbon in the leading edges and **fibreglass in the spine, where the crashes land**. One serious kite carries four different spars, each chosen for its station.²

Third, bridle and line. The bridle is fixed geometry setting angle of attack — measure it before blaming anything else. Line is Dyneema for anything that matters, because stretch is latency. Twenty to thirty metres to start; **thirty-five is team convention**. Fourth, **the small parts**: ferrules \$1.95–3.95, standoffs \$4.95–5.95, nocks \$3.95, leading edges \$6.95–15.95. **A kite is the rare expensive object that is fully field-repairable for under twenty dollars a part.**³

Fifth, how they interact. Stiffer frame, lower-stretch cloth and a tighter bridle give you faster, crisper, less forgiving and more fragile; softer, stretchier and looser gives floatier and more tolerant of gusts and of you. Vents are the third axis — cutting mesh bleeds pressure, which is why one atelier sells **the same kite six times over**, a heavier spar at each step up the range.²

\$410–450

THE SIX-MODEL WIND LADDER OF ONE QUAD — **1–6 MPH THROUGH 25–55**, A DIFFERENT SPAR WEIGHT IN EACH. THE FULL SUITE IS **\$2,560** AT LIST, AND THE MAKER SIGNS EVERY KITE³

THE CHATTER · THE DISRUPTION, FROM A MAN WHO OWNS BOTH

The quad market's inventor held the patents; they expired, and the field moved. From a long-time owner on the English forum, in April: **"The construction quality of the Freileins that I have is probably a step above that of my Revolutions in terms of uniformity and detail."** Same post, after a year of use: "I have neither busted a spar, had a stitch come undone, nor had any bits fall off!" The subreddit's January consensus is blunter — the original maker is "the original innovator, but the competition now makes better kites." And the starter advice is one sentence: *just get the Djuice*. At **\$210–220** plus \$55 for lines and handles — the lines are **not** included, which is the category's standard trap.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE MONEY STOPS WORKING

The ladder is short. Entry \$90–150, serious \$200–300, then **a long flat stretch where \$410 and \$575 buy specificity — a narrower wind band, a faster rotation, a finish — not capability**. On the incumbent's premium tier: "The bars are way too expensive and the Reflex spring unnecessary." On the hierarchy: **"all are good kites, none of them are a bad choice."** And the regret is never the kite — it is the bundled kit: "not the best parts... shorter lines than are typically used." **Buy from the atelier, buy the handles properly, skip the kit.**⁵

THE GRAIL TIER IS THREE PEOPLE WITH SEWING MACHINES

The custom world is small and named. An American atelier takes **custom colours at +\$50**, **"subject to design review," six to eight weeks** — no deposit drama, just a queue. A North Carolina shop builds a **93-inch mesh quad to order at \$575**. And the dual-line benchmark is one Englishman: **"None are built to a higher standard than Benson"** — whose website no longer resolves.⁶

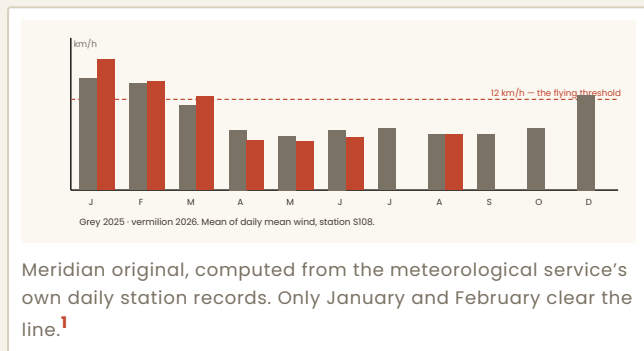
SOURCES 1 Sailcloth weights, stretch and tear behaviour from a 2021 Drachenforum thread among named builders, including the permeability correction. 2 Spar construction and frame composition from a maker's technical copy and the spar lists of five current kites; line conventions from two forum threads. 3 Part, spar, line and accessory prices on makers' own pages, 2 October 2026; the wind ladder, its spar weights and the signing note from the atelier's product page. 4 A forum post of 6 April 2026 and a subreddit thread of 21 January 2026; entry-quad pricing from the maker's page. 5 Quotations as dated in the thread records, attributed to pseudonymous posters. 6 Commissioning terms and lead times on the atelier's shop pages; the North Carolina custom quad on its own site; the Benson verdict from a thread of 7 September 2020 — that maker's domain did not resolve.

THE DEEP END · THE WIND, AND THE NINETY DAYS

Between April and October, across two years, not one day at Marina Barrage averaged twelve kilometres an hour. Not one

This desk downloaded the station data rather than quoting the climatology. It changes the shopping list completely.

The published climatology says Singapore's mean surface wind is about two metres a second, that the strongest winds come with the northeast monsoon in January and February, and that April, May, October and November are "light and variable." True, and not actionable. So this desk pulled every available month of daily records for the **Marina Barrage station** and computed the thing a flier actually needs.¹



The monthly means are bad enough — 12.7 km/h in January 2026, 10.5 in February, 4.8 in April and 4.7 in May. The decisive figure is the share of days whose daily mean reached twelve kilometres an hour: **January, 58 per cent. February, 32. March, 10. April through October, across both years: zero.**¹

Singapore is not windless; it is gusty on top of near-dead air — mean daily maxima run 25 to 37 km/h. There are flyable windows in any month, but sustained, kite-shaped wind only from mid-December to mid-March. Standard and vented sails, which dominate the global market, are **furniture here for seven months**: the honest quiver is ultralight first, standard second, vented never. Publishing on 3 October, you are at the bottom of the trough.¹

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS, AND WHERE YOU MAY ACTUALLY FLY

Days 1–14, spend nothing. Read the free quad curriculum end to end, then pull the wind data for your own field. **Days 15–30:** fly something cheap in real wind and find one

person. **Days 31–60, buy once:** here the light-wind dual-line at \$200 is arguably the first purchase, not the second; on quad, the \$210 entry plus \$55 of lines and handles.²

Marina Barrage, in the authority's own words: no permit needed to turn up and fly, first come first served — but **no flying at night**, and **"no laying of demarcating materials, such as strings, sticks, or tape,"** which rules out marking a flying box. Organised groups must write in. The ceiling is national: **not above 200 feet, nor within 5km of an aerodrome.** Thirty-metre lines at forty-five degrees put you around 21 metres, so the limit binds on big single-line, not on quad.³

THE SCEPTIC · A HOBBY WHOSE INSTITUTIONS HAVE BEEN DYING IN PUBLIC FOR 27 YEARS

In February 1999 a maker warned: **"As the market shrinks, we don't just lose retail stores. We lose manufacturers which means you fliers see less selection, fewer new designs, and slower innovation."** You can check his homework by typing URLs. The canonical American kitemaking supply house now **redirects to an unrelated domain**; the spar distributor's site is a placeholder; the dual-line grail maker, the European federation and three retailers all fail to resolve. The flagship magazine's last article is dated **8 September 2015**, the rulebook has not changed since **1 April 2017**, and the world championship records nothing after 2018. In 2005 another counted it: of ten fliers followed into competition, **six were gone within five years.** Last week the liveliest corner of the main forum was people selling **1982 Flexifoils and vintage kites found in arrow boxes** — while the growth is on a subreddit of LED night kites that passes through none of these institutions.⁴

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK TOMORROW'S HOBBY

Stained glass & leaded panels — copper foil against lead came.

Scale model building — the airbrush and the weathering culture.

Rockhounding & fossil hunting — field collecting, and the law.

SOURCES ¹ Singapore's climatology from the meteorological service's own climate pages; the monthly means, threshold-day shares and daily maxima were computed by us from that service's daily records for station S108, Marina Barrage, downloaded month by month for 2025 and 2026. The computation is ours; the observations are the agency's. Wind ranges are each maker's published figures. ² The atelier's own published tutorial sequence; prices as sourced on p16. ³ Marina Barrage etiquette and the no-permit position quoted from the water agency's own visitor pages; the height and aerodrome limits quoted verbatim from the national aeronautical information publication, section ENR 5.5, dated 12 June 2025. ⁴ The 1999 and 2005 essays from the kite magazine's own archive; every dead or redirected domain was tested on 2 October 2026.

FITNESS · THE MAINTENANCE DOSE

Four weeks of squeezing a wall took nine points off systolic. One session a week keeps most of it; none loses all of it

The held thread closes: the trial this desk could not read in September published on Monday, effect sizes and all.

A hundred adults with normal to high-normal blood pressure did four weeks of lower-body isometric training, three times a week, then were randomised to **three, two, one or zero sessions a week** for four more, against a control. Published **29 September**.¹

At four weeks, against control: systolic **-9.45 mmHg**, diastolic **-5.47**, mean arterial pressure **-6.80** — all significant. These are the numbers held back in September because the publisher refused the page; they are standard deviations, not confidence intervals, and printed as published.¹

The maintenance finding is the useful one. At eight weeks the three, two and one-session groups all held onto their systolic and arterial reductions, significantly more so at three. The **zero-session group reverted** to levels no different from control. Only the three-a-week group kept the improvements in peripheral resistance, heart-rate variability and baroreceptor sensitivity. The authors' own summary: cutting to one or two sessions "can partially attenuate the rate at which BP adaptations regress."¹

≈20

PARTICIPANTS PER ARM, ONCE A HUNDRED PEOPLE ARE SPLIT FIVE WAYS — WHICH IS THE HONEST LIMIT ON EVERY MAINTENANCE COMPARISON ABOVE. EIGHT WEEKS TOTAL, AND NOBODY IN THE TRIAL WAS HYPERTENSIVE¹

THE CHATTER · TEN MINUTES A DAY, AND THE NUMBER THAT DID NOT MOVE

A second trial published the same day: **52 office workers**, twelve weeks, three to six bouts a day of stairs, brisk walking, squats or push-ups, one to three minutes each — about **ten minutes a day** in total. At twelve weeks the intervention group's systolic fell **4.6 mmHg (95% CI 2.36–6.84)**, diastolic **2.4 (0.53–3.27)**, and perceived stress **2.5 points (1.87–4.67)**. **Body mass index did not change at all** — and that is the most useful sentence in the paper. Ten minutes of broken-up movement is a blood-pressure and stress intervention, not a body-composition one. Anyone selling it as the latter is selling something else. **Fifty-two people, one workplace, no stated blinding.**²

And a number your watch already computes. Across **75,308 adults** followed a median 21.9 years, with 3,855 cancer deaths, lower heart-rate reserve carried a hazard ratio of **1.05 per ten per cent lower** and slower **five-minute heart-rate recovery** 1.06 per ten beats — *independent of cardiorespiratory fitness*, which is what makes it more than a proxy. The practical version: one hard effort a week, and record the drop at five minutes. The ratios are small and the cohort affluent and health-seeking.³

THE SCEPTIC · "A BIT LIKE THE WILD WEST"

Your tracker says forty-five, the blood test says fifty-four, your licence says fifty-two. **Tony Wyss-Coray**, professor of neurology at Stanford, on the biological-age industry in September: **"Right now, it's a bit like the wild West."** And: "There are all these different companies advertising tests, often with some kind of powder they want to sell you that's never been tested in humans in a clinical trial." **No direct-to-consumer clock is approved as a diagnostic**; they are wellness products. Researchers elsewhere note the clocks "do not always agree with one another, even when used on the same person," shifting with diet, illness and **time of day**. Prices run from US\$30 to over US\$1,000. **The steelman: two sixty-year-olds genuinely can be on different trajectories.**⁴

General information, not medical advice. Blood-pressure training is not a substitute for treatment.

SOURCES 1 Swift, Pedlar, Coleman, Buckley and Wiles, "Isometric exercise training and blood pressure control," *BMJ Open Sport & Exercise Medicine*, 29 September 2026 — abstract via a literature index after the journal refused us for a second issue; sample, randomisation, effect sizes and conclusion as published. The limitations section could not be read. 2 Liu and Liang, "Workplace-embedded exercise-snack," *Acta Psychologica*, 29 September 2026; the confidence intervals are within-group. 3 Meernik and colleagues, "Markers of Autonomic Function and Cancer Mortality Risk," *JACC: Advances*, 18 September 2026; hazard ratios adjusted for cardiorespiratory fitness. 4 Stanford Medicine, 23 September 2026; the multiple-clock disagreement and price range from a separate academic explainer of 4 May 2026, dated here as such.

DEPARTURES · WHAT HAS CHANGED

The invitation goes out in five weeks. The seat flies in fifteen months

Singapore Airlines will show its new long-haul cabins on 7 November. Entry into service has already slipped from last year's target to the first quarter of 2027.

The reveal is at Marina Bay Sands on **Saturday 7 November**, to selected top-tier frequent flyers: an all-new First, Business, Premium Economy and Economy, a reworked dining service, and the first full overhaul of the entertainment system **since 2013**. The hardware that matters: **doors in Business**, a staggered 1-2-1 layout sleeping *parallel* to the aisle rather than angled, fully flat, and gate-to-gate low-orbit connectivity.¹

And the caveat is the point. Entry into service has moved to **the first quarter of 2027** from a target of mid-2026 — supply-chain constraints and a certification delay on one seat. The programme is reported at **S\$1.1bn across 41 A350-900s**, conceived in late 2024 as the answer to the Boeing 777-9's own delays. A fix for one aircraft's lateness, running late.¹

The dining half lands first. Announced **29 September**: more than a hundred new or refreshed dishes, and from November new wines and **Christofle chinaware** in the forward cabins, worked from a historic pattern with the airline's batik motifs — finer in First, bolder in Business.²

6.00m

PASSENGERS THROUGH CHANGI IN **AUGUST**, AND **46.7 MILLION** IN THE YEAR TO AUGUST, AGAINST A RECORD 69.98 MILLION FOR 2025. TERMINAL 5 COMPLETES **MID-2030**; THE THIRD RUNWAY IS ESTIMATED OPERATIONAL **Q4 2027**³

THE CHATTER · ONE NEW ROUTING CHANGES THIS ISSUE'S OWN TRAVEL MATHS

From **26 October** Singapore Airlines flies **Singapore–Barcelona–Madrid five times a week**, restructuring the existing twice-weekly Barcelona service — Madrid becomes its fifteenth European destination and its second in Spain after **twenty-two years away**. The Milan–Barcelona service ends on 27 October. **The practical consequence for the Grand Tour overleaf**: three weeks after this issue, a Singapore flyer can reach Madrid on one aircraft and connect into Porto on a short Iberian hop — a materially better routing to northern Portugal than existed last month. Elsewhere the Middle East restarts slip a seventh time: **Dubai moves to 2 December**, while **Riyadh opens on 1 December**, ending a twelve-year gap — a route absent for a decade starting one day before the flagship Gulf city.⁴

CORRECTIONS TO THIS DESK'S OWN PIPELINE

Scoot's Okinawa service is not new. This desk had it pencilled for November 2026; it began **15 December 2025**. The real delta: **Okinawa goes from four to five weekly flights** in October. Same announcement — **Guiyang from 26 October**, three weekly, from **S\$158**, a seventeenth mainland Chinese city; Hat Yai, Phuket, Clark and Kota Kinabalu gain frequencies; Phu Quoc goes daily in January.⁵

The cross-border rail link is January 2027, not end-2026 — Woodlands North declared complete on 4 September. Four kilometres, five minutes, **10,000 passengers an hour each way**, both countries' clearance in one building. (p5 carries a February aim; this desk prints both rather than choosing.)⁶

THE SCEPTIC · THE LOUNGE ARITHMETIC NOBODY DOES

Singapore Airlines is spending **S\$45m** rebuilding its Terminal 2 lounges, the Gold lounge doubling with its own showers. Completion: **mid-2027**. Set that beside the cabin programme's slip to early 2027 and the pattern is plain: **every premium promise here is dated after the aircraft meant to carry it**. Anyone booking a long-haul fare on the strength of the November event should book the aeroplane that exists.¹³

SOURCES 1 The reveal, cabin specification, service slip and programme cost from three specialist aviation outlets reproducing the airline's own statements; its newsroom returned not-found on every path. 2 The dining announcement of 29 September 2026 via a specialist outlet. 3 Traffic figures on Changi Airport Group's own statistics page; Terminal 5 and runway timings on its future-developments page. 4 The Madrid announcement of 8 May and the 1 October advisory via reporting that reproduces the releases. 5 The carrier's 20 August network announcement via a Singapore outlet, its own media centre having refused us. 6 The transport authority's 4 September statement via a Singapore outlet; its own newsroom stops at 2021.

DEPARTURES · THE RULES, AND THE ASH

From 1 November you pay Japan's consumption tax at the till and claim it back at the airport

The daily cap on consumables and the sealed-bag ritual both go. And the rail pass went up two days ago.

From the tourism agency's own page: from 1 November 2026 a visitor pays the full tax-inclusive price in the shop, and **"the amount equivalent to consumption tax will be refunded after the customs inspection upon departure."** The threshold stays at **¥5,000 per store per day**, excluding tax. Two irritants vanish: the **¥500,000 daily cap on consumables** and the **sealed-packaging requirement** that made a bag of souvenirs unopenable until you left.¹

The practical effect is a cash-flow change, not a saving. You float the tax for the length of the trip and queue for it at the airport. Against that, you may finally open the sweets.¹

¥53,000

THE SEVEN-DAY ORDINARY RAIL PASS FROM 1 OCTOBER — UP ¥3,000, THE FIRST REVISION IN THREE YEARS, AROUND FIVE TO SIX PER CENT. FOURTEEN-DAY ¥84,000, TWENTY-ONE-DAY ¥105,000. THE 2023 REVISION WAS ROUGHLY SEVENTY PER CENT²

One more Japanese line item has already moved: the departure tax tripled to **¥3,000 a head on 1 July**, applying to everyone leaving by air or sea, residents included. Receipts are projected near ¥130bn this year, earmarked for overtourism measures. An electronic travel authorisation is slated for 2028 — a watch item, not a 2026 one.³

THE CHATTER · CARRY IT, DO NOT USE IT

Power-bank rules have stopped being about watt-hours and started being about behaviour. The international framework is unchanged — **under 100Wh unrestricted, 100–160Wh by airline approval, above 160Wh prohibited** — but carriers have gone much further. **Lufthansa Group, from 25 August:** a maximum of **two** power banks, no use in flight, no charging a power bank from aircraft power, no charging a device from one, and stowage in the seat pocket or under the seat rather than overhead. Emirates has banned onboard use since October last year. **The pattern across carriers is now: bring it, keep it where you can see it, and do not switch it on.** Pack the laptop charged.⁴

IN BRIEF

Europe's entry system is done; the authorisation is not.

The Entry/Exit System has been fully deployed at all Schengen crossings since **10 April 2026**, logging more than **60 million** movements in six months. **ETIAS remains scheduled for the final quarter of 2026**, as a soft launch with at least six months in which travellers are encouraged but not required to hold one. *The EU's own pages would not yield a body, so that date is corroborated, not read at source.*⁵

Anak Krakatau is not finished. The **6 September** eruption sent plumes to roughly 6,100 and 15,200 metres, closed **eight Indonesian airports** including both Jakarta fields, and cancelled **1,558 flights**, affecting about **170,000 passengers**. The airports have reopened; the volcano stays at the second-highest alert level.⁶

THE SCEPTIC · A REFUND SYSTEM IS A QUEUE WITH EXTRA STEPS

Japan is swapping a point-of-sale exemption for a departure refund: an **anti-fraud measure dressed as a convenience**. The sealed-bag rule existed because tax-free consumables were being resold domestically, and the new system solves that by holding your money until the state has seen you leave. **The net depends entirely on the airport queue** — which nobody can tell you yet, because it starts in four weeks.¹

SOURCES 1 Japan Tourism Agency's own tax-free page, quoted verbatim: the refund mechanism, the ¥5,000 threshold and the abolition of the consumables cap and sealed packaging. 2 The rail-pass revision as announced by the rail group and reported by a national news agency; the operator's own price table would not render. 3 The departure-tax increase and revenue projection from two dated reports. 4 The international framework and the named carriers' rules from four trade and consumer aviation outlets. 5 Deployment status and movement counts from a legal-practice briefing and the agency's quarterly report listing; the EU's own pages returned titles only, so the fourth-quarter date is **not** read at the EU source. 6 Eruption, plume heights, closures and flight counts from three contemporaneous reports. 7 Three reports read at source.

THE GRAND TOUR • PORTO & THE DOURO

The vines are not gold yet, and the harvest finished in August

Both halves of the romantic October pitch are wrong this year. What is actually true about this fortnight is better, and most of it is on rails.

Test the postcard first. **The 2026 vindima ran early, not late.** On 5 August the president of the Douro growers' association and the director-general of the valley's viticulture body said picking had already started for sparkling bases, with whites days away — an advance of **eight to fifteen days** on normal timing. And the leaves do not turn in early October: the terraces go gold, copper and plum from **late October into November**. In the first ten days of the month you get neither the harvest nor the colour.¹

So here is the honest “go now.” The **Linha do Douro** is halfway through a roughly €110–118m electrification between Marco de Canaveses and Peso da Régua, which requires three separate closures. The first ran **3 November 2025 to 2 April 2026** — five months of replacement buses. Trains returned in April, and **the second phase is expected to begin in November 2026**. October is the gap between them.²

And the historic train stops on 18 October. Fifty-one trips ran from 6 June: Régua to Pinhão to Tua and back, departing Régua at 15:00, back by 18:22 — about three hours, **254 seats** in five early-twentieth-century carriages, port and live music on boarding. **€60 adult, €32 for a child aged four to twelve.** Two more weekends, then it is done for the year.³

133mm

OF RAIN ACROSS ABOUT **TWELVE RAIN DAYS** — OCTOBER IS PORTO'S WETTEST MONTH BAR NOVEMBER. DAYS ARE MILD AT 20–21°C, EVENINGS DROP TO 12–13, AND THE GRANITE HOLDS THE DAMP. **PACK A SHELL, NOT AN UMBRELLA: IT IS WINDY ON THE BRIDGES**⁴

Two things did go right, and both are new. The Douro has its **first Michelin star** — Schistó, at a hotel near Peso da Régua, in the 2026 Portuguese guide announced on 10 March: an open kitchen, one ten-course menu, built largely on estate produce. And

SOURCES 1 A Portuguese economic news service, 5 August 2026, read at source, quoting the growers' association president and the viticulture body's director-general on the advanced harvest; the seasonal colour description from a Portuguese travel publication read at source. 2 The electrification programme, its cost band and its phased closures from Portuguese rail and regional reporting; the first closure's dates and the April restoration as reported. 3 The historic train's season, schedule, duration, seating, carriages and both fares as published by the operator and reproduced in two Portuguese reports. 4 Porto climate normals 1991–2020 as tabulated from the national meteorological institute's series. 5 The Michelin Guide Portugal 2026, announced 10 March 2026 — read from the guide's own press PDF after its web pages rendered blank for this desk. 6 Two Portuguese outlets, 5–6 August 2026 and July 2026, read at source. 7 Routing structure as described on **p19** and sourced there. 8 Neighbourhood trade-offs and the quoted line from the Rick Steves Portugal forum, read at source; Reddit, TripAdvisor and FlyerTalk all refused this desk, and nothing here is attributed to them. 9 Porto's municipal tourist tax, its rate, its cap and its age threshold, in force since 1 December 2024.

Porto had its best Michelin year ever, four new one-stars in a single edition.⁵

THE SCEPTIC • THE VALLEY IS IN A PRICE CRISIS, NOT A ROMANCE

The most interesting thing in the Douro this autumn is not the light. **2026 was the third consecutive difficult harvest.** Growers received letters cancelling grape orders; fruit was picked with no buyer, or sold with **no agreed price and no payment date**, at levels that do not cover the cost of production. On 5 and 6 August producers publicly demanded immediate measures to move the crop at fair prices. The terraced schist that photographs so well is **hand-worked, mechanisable only at vast cost, and currently uneconomic** — which is the real reason to look closely at it this year. A visitor buying a €53 flight of forty-year-old tawny is participating in the part of the business that still works; the part on the hillside is not.⁶

Getting there changes this month. There is no direct service from Singapore; the usual routings run through the Gulf, Istanbul or a northern European hub. But from **26 October** Singapore Airlines reaches **Madrid** five times a week on one aircraft (**p19**), and Madrid connects into Porto on a short Iberian hop. Three weeks after this issue, that is the cleanest routing to northern Portugal a Singapore passport has had in twenty-two years.⁷

WHERE TO BASE YOURSELF

Ribeira is the postcard and the noise. **Gaia**, across the water, has the argument in its favour that one poster put best: it has “the best view, which is looking at Porto, rather from it” — with the practical rider to check the lift works, because the hill is real. **Baixa** for walking, **Foz** for the sea, **Bonfim** for the rent. And the Douro question: base in Porto and day-trip, or sleep at Régua or Pinhão. The valley people say the second; the three-day visitor should hear the first (**p22**).⁸

One gift for a family: Porto's tourist tax is **€3 a night, capped at seven consecutive nights — and it applies only to guests over thirteen.** A twelve-year-old stays free of it.⁹

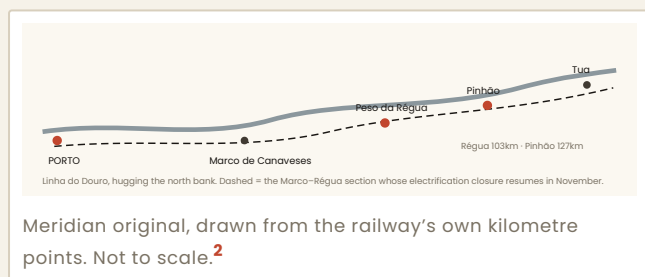
THE GRAND TOUR · THE LODGES, THE LINE AND THE MONEY

Fifty-three euros buys ten, twenty, thirty and forty years in one sitting. It is the best value in Gaia and it is the only tariff published

Four of the famous houses do not print a price at all. The train east costs under twenty euros and beats a two-hundred-dollar tour.

Only one lodge publishes a complete current tariff, which makes it the price anchor for the whole of Vila Nova de Gaia. A cellar visit with three ports runs **€23** for fifty minutes; a five-port tour of the house's founding, **€35**; a three-hour workshop, **€100**; a six-port session including vintages, **€170**. And the one to book: **€53 for a vertical of ten, twenty, thirty and forty-year-old tawnies**, ninety minutes, four glasses. Four decades of the same wine, side by side, for the price of a decent dinner.¹

The others keep their prices off the page. Taylor's publishes a thirteen-language circuit ending in three tastings, and no fee. Graham's a tutored tasting, no fee. Cálem a fado show and no fee — and sits at the foot of the bridge, first door off the lower deck, which tells you what it is.¹



THE CHATTER · WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY, AND WHERE THEY CONTRADICT THE BROCHURES

The train is the value play. One poster priced it at “less than 20 euro each way” against **US\$200–300** for an organised tour, Porto to Pinhão in under two and a half hours, with restaurants and two wineries walkable from the station. **Go east:** “the lower part of the river valley near Porto is not as scenic as up river.” **But do not spend a short trip on a long day** — with three days there is “plenty to see and do” without “a long long day up the Douro.” That cuts against every operator's pitch. And from September this year: “the windows of the train were covered with graffiti, and we could not see out.” Reddit, TripAdvisor and FlyerTalk all refused this desk; none of this is theirs.³

THE SCEPTIC · THE FAMOUS BOOKSHOP, AND THE THING NOBODY ADMITS

Livraria Lello sells timed entry at roughly **€8**, deductible against a book, rising to about €50 for priority. The forum verdict is not kind: a “**definite tourist trap**”, “a beautiful bookstore with way too many people,” and **even Harry Potter devotees calling it overrated**. On photography the accounts flatly contradict each other — signs saying it is barred, alongside reports of a permitted early hour and staff who “didn't seem to be batting an eyelid.” **This desk could read neither the policy nor the prices: the ticketing pages sit behind a bot wall.** Check by telephone before queueing.⁴

WHAT THINGS ACTUALLY COST, READ AT SOURCE

Metro single **€1.40–2.30** by zone from 1 January 2026; the all-zone day pass **€7.75**, three days **€16.55**. The Clérigos tower **€10**, free under ten. The six-bridges cruise **from €18**; Porto to Pinhão and back with a visit, **from €94**. A francesinha with a beer is around **€12** — crowd-sourced, because the famous houses decline to publish one.⁵

The dish, honestly: bread, layered cured and roast meats, melted cheese, a hot beer-and-tomato sauce, a fried egg, buried in chips. Enormous, and a single meal for a day. The queue-out-the-door one is the famous one; the connoisseur's pick is the Santa Catarina room with the local queue.⁶

SOURCES 1 One lodge's complete tariff on its own site, 2 October 2026, with every price as published; the other houses' pages loaded without prices, and one returned a bot-verification page. 2 Station kilometre points from the railway operator's own line data; the electrification section as sourced on **p21**. 3 Rick Steves Portugal forum threads, quoted with their posters' handles and dates, including a September 2026 report on the carriage windows. Reddit, TripAdvisor and FlyerTalk were refused and are not cited. 4 Ticket tiers from resellers and guides rather than the shop, whose pages are behind a verification wall; the verdicts from the same forum board; the photography contradiction reported, not resolved. 5 Metro fares on the operator's own site, effective 1 January 2026; tower and cruise prices on their operators' pages; the meal figure is a crowd-sourced index. 6 A city guide; no prices appear in it.

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

The race is six days away and the November sumo was gone before most people knew it was on sale

Every row below was re-checked against a venue, promoter or official seller. A dozen candidates failed and are named at the foot.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 9–11 OCT** ★ **Formula 1 Singapore Grand Prix**
MARINA BAY · **A SPRINT WEEKEND**, NEW FOR SINGAPORE. PADANG NIGHTS — FRIDAY JJ LIN, SATURDAY THE KILLERS, **SUNDAY LANA DEL REY AND JANET JACKSON**. **NO PRICE PUBLISHED ON ANY PAGE THIS DESK COULD OPEN**¹
- 7 OCT** **Hans Zimmer Live — The Next Level**
THE KALLANG · VENUE'S OWN BILL; NO PRICE PUBLISHED²
- 17–18 OCT** **BIGBANG — 〈XX : COSMOS〉**
THE KALLANG · TWO NIGHTS, FROM THE VENUE'S OWN LISTING²
- 13–22 NOV** ★ **Singapore Writers Festival, 30th edition**
"HIDDEN IN PLAIN SIGHT" · **FESTIVAL PASS S\$24 EARLY BIRD, S\$30 AFTER; YOUTH PASS S\$12**, 100+ PROGRAMMES · AMITAV GHOSH 14 NOV · LIMITED AVAILABILITY³
- 8 NOV** **Deepavali**
A SUNDAY, SO MONDAY THE 9TH IS THE HOLIDAY IF YOUR REST DAY FALLS ON IT. **THE LITTLE INDIA LIGHT-UP DATES ARE STILL UNPUBLISHED** — BUT THE LIGHTS ARE CONFIRMED ON BY **17 OCTOBER**, WHEN A COMMUNITY BODY RUNS A GUIDED EVENING WALK OF THEM⁴
- 4–6 DEC** **Singapore International Marathon**
ENTRY CLOSED 30 SEPTEMBER; MARATHON, HALF AND TEAM CHALLENGE SOLD OUT. A SPECTATOR EVENT NOW²
- 17–22 DEC** ★ **BTS — 〈ARIRANG〉, four nights**
NATIONAL STADIUM · **VIP S\$388 DOWN TO S\$148 PLUS BOOKING FEE** · GENERAL SALE WAS 5 JUNE; **NO SOLD-OUT NOTICE ON THE OFFICIAL PAGE**, SO RESALE TERRITORY, NOT A SELL-OUT CLAIM⁵

JAPAN & THE REGION

THE ONES WITH A TICKET CLOCK

- 8–22 NOV** **Kyushu Basho — and you have missed it**
FUKUOKA · OPENED **19 SEPTEMBER**; THE ASSOCIATION'S OWN SITE NOW READS **SOLD OUT, ALL FIFTEEN DAYS, NO SAME-DAY SALES**⁶
- 9–10 OCT** **Takayama Autumn Festival**
GIFU · ELEVEN LANTERN-HUNG FLOATS AND THE KARAKURI MARIONETTES · **FREE** · COLLIDES EXACTLY WITH THE GRAND PRIX⁷
- 14 NOV–28 MAR** ★ **Masterworks from the Musée d'Orsay**
TOBIKAN, UENO · **¥2,400 ADULT, UNDER-18S FREE** · FRIDAYS TO 20:00 · **CLOSED 22 DEC–3 JAN** — EXACTLY WHEN A SINGAPORE FAMILY WOULD BE THERE⁸
- 29 SEP–20 DEC** **Hiroshige: New Perspectives on Edo Japan**
TOKYO NATIONAL MUSEUM, HONKAN · OPEN TO 20:00 · PRICES NOT PUBLISHED ON THE PAGE READ⁹
- 18 OCT** **Edo in Focus: treasures from the British Museum — closes**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM · THE CENTENARY SHOW, TWO WEEKS LEFT⁸
- 28 NOV** ★ **Niseko United opens**
ALL FOUR RESORTS · NIGHT SKIING FROM 12 DEC · **PEAK PRICING STARTS 24 DEC**: ¥13,500 A DAY AGAINST ¥8,800 EITHER SIDE · **CHILD RATE COVERS AGES 4–12**¹⁰
- 8 JAN–4 APR** **Final Fantasy, 40th anniversary**
TOKYO NATIONAL MUSEUM · PRICES AND ON-SALE NOT YET PUBLISHED — WATCH FOR THE RELEASE⁹
- 11–31 JAN** **Australian Open 2027**
MELBOURNE · THE TOURNAMENT'S OWN SITE GIVES THE SPAN; **NO ON-SALE DATE PUBLISHED**¹¹

PLANNING NOTES · ONE LESSON, AND WHAT FAILED VERIFICATION

The sumo is the lesson of the issue. The on-sale was 19 September, four lottery rounds ran before it, and all fifteen days were gone by the time anyone read about it. The habit is not watching for the tournament; it is **setting an alarm for the on-sale**. **For the twelve-year-old:** the Orsay show admits under-18s free on a ¥2,400 adult ticket, and the Niseko child rate runs to twelve — she turns thirteen in July, so this is the **last season at child pricing**. **Dropped for failing verification:** Christmas at the Gardens (no 2026 dates published anywhere); four arena shows absent from the promoter's own slate; a December esports major whose organisers' site returns nothing; four Singapore exhibitions this desk can confirm are on but cannot date; the Japanese winter-illumination calendar, where every circulating date is last season's; and the Asian Games, whose **closing ceremony is tomorrow** and whose organisers publish no date this desk could read. **Post Malone stays off this page** — cancelled, and barred by standing order.¹²

SOURCES 1 formulal.com's own 2026 Singapore page and the promoter's own entertainment page, both read 2 October 2026; the ticketing page would not open, so no price is printed, and session clock times are omitted because the times returned were localised by the fetch. 2 thekallang.com.sg, the venue's own site, for the October shows and the marathon's closed entry. 3 singaporewritersfestival.com: dates, theme, pass prices and keynotes. 4 The Ministry of Manpower's gazetted list, including the substitute-day wording; the light-up confirmation is a People's Association listing for 17 October 2026. The organising body publishes no 2026 light-up dates. 5 The venue's own BTS page for the dates, prices and booking fees; the ticketing platform refused us. 6 The sumo association's own ticketing site and English homepage. 7 The official Hida-Takayama tourism site. 8 The Tokyo Metropolitan Art Museum's own exhibition pages. 9 Tokyo National Museum. 10 niseko.ne.jp's own lift-pass page. 11 ausopen.com. 12 Each dropped item was checked against the promoter, venue, organiser or museum named.

THE TABLE • WHAT HAS JUST OPENED

Six of this month's "new openings" were not new. Two of those were ours

Four had been trading since last year. The other two this desk had already reviewed itself, in July and August — and only the ledger caught it.

Start with the one that is genuinely new, because there is only one. **KOKO Kawane** opened at The Star Vista on **1 October** — two days ago. It ties a Japanese-style patisserie to a Shizuoka tea farm worked by the same family since the 1600s: single-origin first-flush Okumidori tencha, **ground to order on a daily micro-mill on the premises**. Lattes S\$8 to S\$12.50, whisked usucha S\$7 to S\$17, cakes S\$10 to S\$14. Walk-in only, directly above the station.¹

Too new to call, and this desk will not pretend otherwise: one launch report exists and no reviews at all. The grinding claim is the thing worth testing, and a weekday mid-afternoon is when you can test it without a queue.¹

Now the part worth printing. Two rooms came to this page as fresh openings and were stopped by MERIDIAN's own venue ledger: one has been in these pages since **No. 116**, the other since **No. 118** — five and three issues ago. Both opened in September, both were being written up this week as new, and both were new to the city's food media. They were not new to us. The ledger exists because this desk ran the same restaurant four times in thirteen issues, and this week it earned its keep by catching the desk twice in one page.²

A venue is not new because a roundup says so. It is new because nobody has written it up before — and the only reliable record of that is your own.

Then the ordinary attrition. Checked against their actual opening dates, a burger bar on this month's best-new list opened **3 April**; a yakitori counter, **15 May**; a pasta room in an October roundup has been

trading since **17 May 2025**, and appears only because it launched a lunch buffet. A doughnut brand credited with a Singapore opening has a launch this desk could locate only in **Kuala Lumpur**.³

THE VERDICT RUN • DECKER BARBECUE, TEN WEEKS ON

Covered at No. 111 on the announcement; the flagship opened **7 August** in the conserved **1956 Bukit Timah fire station** — 4,000 square feet, 120 seats, and a **fourteen-foot, three-tonne offset smoker shipped from Texas**, which the restaurant says is the only one in Southeast Asia, running meats up to twelve hours. **It has held up.** A late-August review praises the wagyu brisket's smoke ring and rendered cap, an unusually serious vegetarian platter, and burnt pineapple with rendang-spiced hot honey — and puts a number on it: **S\$55–65 a head** for dinner with a starter and a beer, with a three-person platter at **S\$38 each** as the value tier. From its own page: **weekdays take reservations, weekends are walk-in only**, and if the booking link shows no slots it is full. No Michelin recognition — stated as an absence, not a snub.⁴

THE SCEPTIC • WHAT A THREE-WEEK WINDOW HONESTLY YIELDS

One room. That is the yield when every candidate's opening date is checked rather than copied, and when the publication's own back catalogue is checked too. The alternative was a page of four confident entries, two of which this magazine had already reviewed. **The failure mode here is not laziness, it is circularity:** food media republish each other's roundups, a September opening becomes an October listing, and a magazine that trusted the listing would print its own August copy back to itself. The only defence is a machine-readable record of what you have already run — and the honest consequence of keeping one is a shorter page.²³

OPENED 1 OCT

VERDICT RUN

TWO CAUGHT BY THE LEDGER

WEEKDAY BOOKING

SOURCES 1 A launch report published 1 October 2026 with venue-supplied imagery, read at source: the farm, the cultivar, the on-site mill, the full price list and the opening promotion. Halal status is not claimed either way because no source states it. 2 *ledgers/table-ledger.md*, this publication's own venue record, which bars a second run inside seven issues; the two venues withheld this week last appeared in Nos. 116 and 118 and are therefore not named again here. 3 Opening dates for each excluded candidate were checked individually against dated reports or the venue's own channels. 4 The restaurant's own site, read 2 October 2026, for both outlets' hours and the reservation policy; the building, seating, smoker and menu detail and the per-head figures from two dated reviews of 7 and 24 August 2026; the Michelin absence checked against the 2026 Singapore selection.

THE UNDERCURRENT · UZBEKISTAN

The eight hundred thousand who were always there

Uzbekistan counted itself for the first time in thirty-seven years and found two per cent more people than it had. Nobody had moved. They had simply been illegal to admit to.

On 30 June the chairman of Uzbekistan's statistics committee announced the preliminary result of the country's first census since 1989: **39,047,321 people**, at 15 January 2026. That was **810,617 more** than the running official estimate — two point one per cent, discovered in a single morning. The working-age cohort alone came in roughly four hundred thousand above where the books had put it.¹

The census ran from 15 January to 28 February, reached **97.3 per cent** coverage, and cost about **twelve US cents a head**, because **82.3 per cent of the population enumerated themselves online** through the national identity platform. Only seventeen per cent needed a knock at the door. It was authorised by decree the previous September.²

Then look at where the missing people were. Tashkent Region was revised from about 3.2 million to **3.8 million**, moving from seventh of the country's fourteen territories to third. Roughly **six hundred thousand of the eight hundred thousand were in one region**, the one wrapped around the capital.²

Nobody moved there between October and January. Those people had been living there for years. What changed was not the population but the penalty for admitting where you lived — because three months before the enumerators arrived, Uzbekistan abolished the *propiska*.³

The enumeration itself is worth a line, because it is the cheapest census anyone has run at this scale. **82.3 per cent of the population counted themselves online**, through the national digital-identity platform; only seventeen per cent needed an enumerator at the door. The whole exercise cost about **twelve US cents a head** and reached 97.3 per cent coverage. A state that could not find six hundred thousand of its own people could, once it stopped penalising them, find them through a login.²

810,617

MORE PEOPLE THAN THE STATE BELIEVED IT HAD — AND ABOUT **602,000** OF THEM IN TASHKENT REGION ALONE, WHICH JUMPED FROM SEVENTH-LARGEST TERRITORY TO THIRD¹²

The *propiska* was the Soviet residency permit, and Uzbekistan kept it for thirty-four years after the Soviet Union stopped existing. Under the 2011 law, permanent registration in the capital was restricted to twelve categories of citizen. Everyone else who lived and worked there did so unregistered — which meant, in practice, without reliable access to the school, the clinic or the formal job that registration unlocks. A new law was signed on 11 July 2025 and came into force on **12 October 2025**, letting any citizen register anywhere.³

A human-rights monitor had described the old system, in 2020, as one in which rural citizens “are forced to live and work in urban areas without registration.” Even the deputy interior minister of the day conceded the point in public: “**The propiska is an outdated system... the word ‘propiska’ will be removed from circulation.**”⁴

Statistical invisibility was not a measurement failure. It was a policy output — and it worked exactly as designed until the design was repealed.

This is the first thing worth taking from Uzbekistan's year of counting. A state that punishes people for being where they are will not be able to find them, and will then mistake its own blindness for data. The census did not discover eight hundred thousand Uzbeks. It discovered what its own rules had been doing to its own numbers.¹³

SOURCES 1 Gazeta.uz's English service, 30 June 2026, read at source: the preliminary total, the 810,617 excess over the running estimate, the urban-rural split, the working-age revision and the attribution to the statistics committee's chairman. 2 The Times of Central Asia, read at source: the enumeration window, the 97.3 per cent coverage, the 82.3 per cent self-enumeration through the national identity platform, the per-capita cost, the September 2025 authorising decree and the Tashkent Region revision from roughly 3.2 to 3.8 million with its change of rank. 3 Gazeta.uz, 12 July 2025, read at source: the signing date, the commencement date, the twelve permitted categories under the superseded 2011 law and the shortened permitted stay without registration. 4 Uzbek Forum for Human Rights, dated 18 February 2020, read at source, for the characterisation of the system and the quoted ministerial remark.

The counting did not stop with people. On 2 September the president reviewed a presentation whose central finding was that **twenty-three per cent of the Uzbek economy — 246 trillion soums — is what the statisticians call the unobserved economy.** In agriculture it is **sixty per cent of turnover.** Of 15.2 million employed people, **6.5 million — forty-two per cent — have undocumented income.** The official formulation is the memorable one: one of every four or five soums of turnover sits outside the statistics.¹

The response is another census. From **15 October to 30 November** — twelve days after this issue — Uzbekistan will count every business in the country. From 1 January 2027 micro and small firms will be drawn into statistical samples only once a year, a concession offered alongside the obligation, and the whole exercise sits inside a national statistics strategy running to 2030.¹²

23%

OF THE ECONOMY IS FORMALLY CLASSIFIED AS **UNOBSERVED** — 246 TRILLION SOUMS, AND SIXTY PER CENT OF ALL AGRICULTURAL TURNOVER. THE BUSINESS CENSUS OPENS **15 OCTOBER**¹

The scale of what is being brought into view is not marginal. The International Labour Organization puts informal employment at around **forty per cent of the Uzbek workforce**, and its country programme, launched in April 2025, targets formalising **300,000** informal workers and improving assistance for **720,000** low-income people. Those are the numbers of a state discovering that a substantial minority of its working population has no contract, no contributions record and no claim on anything it pays for.⁴

Now put the sequence in order, because the order is the argument. Abolish the residency permit, October 2025. Count the people, January to February 2026. Restrict cash settlement, from April. Count the businesses, from October. Each step converts an unregistered life into a legible one, and each was presented as a liberation.³

The liberations are real. Registration is what makes a clinic, a school place and a formal wage available; a worker counted is a worker who can be insured. Formalisation is not a trick, and nobody in Tashkent is pretending the old arrangement served the people living under it.⁴

But visibility is being offered as a gift and will arrive as a bill. The eight hundred thousand who appeared in the ledger this year are the same eight hundred thousand who will appear in the tax base next year. The state is pre-paying for consent — a one per cent turnover tax for the smallest traders, a raised threshold, a promise of lighter statistical reporting — and the schools and clinics that registration unlocks will arrive more slowly than the receipts do. That is not cynicism about Tashkent's intentions. It is the ordinary sequencing of state-building, and it is why formalisation programmes fail when protection lags registration: the ILO's own framing insists the insurance has to travel with the paperwork, because otherwise activity simply goes back underground.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · COUNTING THEM DOES NOT EMPLOY THEM

The sharpest dissent comes from an analyst writing in a regional outlet in August, and it is not about tax. On his reading the census discovery is not a story about legibility at all but about **absorption**: internal migration ran **252,800 people in 2025, of whom 121,000 — forty-eight per cent — went to Tashkent city and region**, exactly as the two historic safety valves narrow. Labour migration to Russia is no longer reliable; the rural economy is not growing into it. **Six hundred thousand people enter the labour market every year, heading for a million a year by 2030**, against 760,000 registered jobseekers and an official unemployment rate of 4.9 per cent that nobody in the argument treats as the real number. Remittances ran **US\$18.9bn in 2025**. *Counting a person does not create a job for them* — and the census also found only **4.8 million** people living in apartment blocks against a prior estimate of 7.1 million, with eighty-six per cent in detached houses, which is a housing-policy problem the state has been planning against the wrong figure for years.⁵

SOURCES 1 Spot.uz's English service, 3 September 2026, read at source: the twenty-three per cent and 246 trillion soums figures, the sixty per cent of agricultural turnover, the 6.5-million-of-15.2-million employment figure, the "one of every four or five soums" formulation, the 2 September presidential review and the business-census dates. 2 Kun.uz, 12 September 2026, read at source in Uzbek: the census window, the once-a-year sampling concession from 1 January 2027 and the 2026–2030 statistics strategy. 3 The cashless-settlement measures taking effect in April 2026 are reported consistently across Uzbek business press but were **not read at an official source**, and are stated here only as the sequence, without figures. 4 The International Labour Organization's own country programme page, read at source: the informality share, the 300,000 formalisation target, the 720,000 assistance target and the April 2025 launch. 5 The Times of Central Asia, 5 August 2026, an opinion piece by an independent analyst, read at source: the internal-migration figures, the labour-market entry projections, the jobseeker count, the unemployment rate, the remittance total and the apartment-block revision.

There is a third-order point, and it is the one worth carrying out of this piece. A legible state is not easily made illegible again. Uzbekistan is building, in about eighteen months, precisely the dataset that any future and less liberal government would need: who lives where, who earns what, which of fifteen million workers were previously invisible, and where the forty-two per cent keep their money. The register does not know what it will be used for.¹

That is not a prediction about Tashkent. It is the oldest observation in the study of states, and James C. Scott made it the spine of *Seeing Like a State*: the cadastral survey, the permanent surname, the standardised measure and the census are not neutral instruments but the preconditions of administration, and they long outlive the administration that introduces them. The Domesday Book was compiled to settle a conquest and was still being cited in English courts eight centuries later.²

What makes Uzbekistan's case unusually clean is the control group. Most states acquired legibility slowly, so the counterfactual is lost. Here the penalty was removed in October and the count ran in January, and the gap between the two numbers — 810,617 — is a direct measurement of how much reality a single administrative rule had been suppressing. Governments rarely get to see the size of their own blind spot that precisely.³

The housing numbers make the point concretely. The census found only **4.8 million** Uzbeks living in apartment blocks against a prior estimate of **7.1 million**, with eighty-six per cent in detached houses. That is not a rounding error in a statistical annexe; it is a country that has been planning its housing, its utilities and its urban transport against a figure wrong by nearly a third — and it will now plan against a better one, which is the case for counting, made without any reference to tax at all.³

The register does not know what it will be used for. That is its whole nature, and the reason every generation has to re-argue who may read it.

The argument against is the obvious and decent one: invisibility is not freedom. The unregistered Tashkent worker was not enjoying privacy; he was being denied a school place. Opacity protects the powerful far more reliably than it protects the poor, and a state that cannot see sixty per cent of its agricultural turnover cannot tax the people profiting from it either. Every one of the eight hundred thousand gains something real on 1 January that they did not have before.⁴

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRADERS' OWN CHANNEL IS TALKING ABOUT

Uzbekistan's public conversation runs through messaging channels rather than forums — the two largest news sites draw roughly 7.4 and 4.7 million monthly visitors and are shifting from text to video. This desk read the business ombudsman's own public channel, the nearest thing to a register of small-trader anxiety. The live material on 1 and 2 October is **not about the census at all**. It is about inspections: an explainer on an entrepreneur's rights before, during and after one; a recovery of **459.6 million soums** in overpaid tax for a trader in Andijan; a **3.1 billion soum** court award against a district administration. *This desk could not confirm the year stamped on those posts, and says so.* But the register is the point: twelve days before a census of every business in the country, the channel small traders actually read is preoccupied with being inspected.⁵

So watch three things, and the first is only twelve days away. Whether the business census opens on 15 October and closes on 30 November, or quietly softens into a voluntary survey. Whether the final census results hold the 810,617 or revise it down. And whether the unobserved share actually moves in the 2027 statistics — because if twenty-three per cent is still twenty-three per cent in two years, the counting was theatre.¹³

When the Financial Times writes this up in November, it will be about the business census, and it will be a good piece. The part worth having first is the sequence: the permit went, then the people appeared, then the cash was restricted, and only then did anyone go looking for the money. **Uzbekistan did not discover eight hundred thousand citizens this year. It stopped making them hide.**

SOURCES 1 Figures as sourced on **p26**: the twenty-three per cent unobserved share, the employment split and the business-census window. 2 James C. Scott, *Seeing Like a State: How Certain Schemes to Improve the Human Condition Have Failed* (Yale University Press, 1998), for the argument that legibility is the precondition of administration; the Domesday Book's long afterlife in English law is a matter of record. 3 Census figures as sourced on **p25**; the October-to-January gap between the repeal and the enumeration is this desk's own framing of those two dated events. 4 The counter-argument is this desk's, not a source's, and is offered as such. 5 Audience figures for the two largest Uzbek news sites appear in an Uzbek media-development summary and were **not read at source**; the ombudsman's public channel was read directly on 2 October 2026, and the three items described are the live posts found there. The year stamp on those posts could not be confirmed.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

Against the wind

Seven governments opened their oil reserves on Friday, and the price of the barrel they cannot reach went up. American payrolls missed by sixty thousand and the long end of the bond market sold off anyway. A rival bidder appeared for a chip company and the price fell nineteen per cent. Fifty batches of rice at a test kitchen put a two-hundred-dollar machine above a six-hundred-dollar one.

None of those is a paradox. Each is a system answering a push with something other than the obvious yield, because the force you can see is not the only one in the room. The useful habit is not to expect the counter-intuitive; it is to ask, before being surprised, which other force was already there.

John Neal put it in 1846, in a line the whole internet now hands to Churchill, who was not yet born when it was written: a certain amount of opposition is a great help to a man. Kites rise against, not with, the wind. Which is true, and is also why — as [p17](#) reports from the station data rather than the brochure — nobody in Singapore has flown a serious kite since March.

Twelve Desks · One World MERIDIAN · No. 121 · 3 October 2026

A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: the Bureau of Labor Statistics' September employment release and the Bureau of Economic Analysis's August income report; the US Treasury's own par and real yield curves, downloaded as data; the Federal Open Market Committee's September statement and three governors' speeches; the Bank of Japan's September decision and its Summary of Opinions, extracted from their own PDFs; the Energy Information Administration's weekly stock and price tables; an executive order and a merger exhibit filed with the Securities and Exchange Commission; four `llama.cpp` pull requests with their review threads; Ethiopia's state news agency; the Ministry of Manpower's gazetted holiday list; the national aeronautical information publication's section on kite flying; and — computed here from the meteorological service's own daily station records rather than quoted — every monthly wind figure on [p17](#). **Corrections in this issue:** two. No. 120 reported that the haze had broken on Wednesday; it had not, and the reading at five this morning is on [p5](#). No. 120 printed a dollar price for a watch that belongs to a different edition of it, two years older; the maker publishes a euro price and no dollar figure at all ([p10](#)). **Refused this desk today:** reddit.com on every route, which is why five desks print a null result rather than a sentiment; the International Energy Agency's own newsroom, on the day it was asked to execute a reserve release; Wikimedia's image host after the first few files; the maritime authority whose incident wording appears on [p4](#); Technics, the Washington Post, Addis Standard, the health and housing ministries' own newsrooms, the Straits Times, CNA and the Business Times at article level; and the Singapore parenting forums on [p13](#).